

From titles to patterns and back again

A corpus-based analysis of the German snowclone [*Der mit X tanzt*] from a constructionist perspective

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This article offers a constructionist approach to the creation of new constructional idioms (CIs) emerging from frequent modifications of fully lexicalized multi-word expressions in German (e.g., [*X kam, sah und Y*] ‘*X came, saw, and Y*’). The process can be described as *constructionalization*, closely related to the concept of *snowclones* which has received increasing attention not only at the interface between phraseology and Construction Grammar, but also in recent research on linguistic creativity. Well-known film or book titles prove to be ideal bases for the emergence of such CIs, with instantiations predominantly used in titling contexts, too (e.g., press headlines, book titles, advertising slogans). This raises two key questions: To what extent are CIs resulting from modification particularly attractive for title contexts, and, vice versa, what role do titles as exposed text positions play in the emergence and consolidation of new CIs? To address these questions and outline the dynamic processes to which fixed multi-word expressions can be subjected even within shorter periods of time, I conduct a corpus-based diachronic examination of such ‘title templates’ in German, using the famous western title *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* (orig. ‘Dances with wolves’) as an example. Based on data from the *German Reference Corpus*, the case study focuses on the following aspects: (1) degree of productivity and schematization, (2) slot filling restrictions and diachronic changes, (3) proportion of title instances and preferences in title types. In addition to ‘slot analyses’, provided by the corpus tool Lexical Pattern Analyzer (*lexpan*), timeline graphs are used to visualize the annual development of modifications over recent decades, yielding more precise insights into the ‘pattern career’ of especially younger lexicalized multi-word expressions created after 1990.

Keywords: constructional idioms, snowclones, linguistic creativity, slot analyses, timeline graphs, contextual entrenchment

1. Introduction

This article deals with the emergence of constructional idioms in German, with a focus on their origin and diachronic development. More particularly, I will focus on a phenomenon that is currently attracting growing attention both in research on the interface of phraseology and Construction Grammar and in recent research on linguistic creativity: the phenomenon of ‘snowclones’. These are defined as a specific subtype of semi-schematic constructions, characterized “by the extension of [a] source construction [...] via partial lexical substitution” (Hartmann & Ungerer 2024: 603). In this paper, I am particularly interested in snowclones that go back to a very specific type of source constructions, namely titles as modern “winged words” (*Geflügelte Worte* in terms of German phraseology, cf. Burger 2015: 48–49), for which it seems characteristic that their patterns are preferably used in title contexts, too, for example as book and film titles, press headlines, or advertising slogans. An illustrative example is [*DER*¹ *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] ‘The one/Those who V_{fin} with NP_{dat}’ which likely originates from the famous western title *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* (orig. *Dances with wolves*, literal translation: ‘(He who) Dances with the wolf’), as instantiated in the following examples, cf. (1).

¹ Small capitals mark fixed construction elements that permit morphological variation (e.g., gender, number). In this case, the forms *Der* (masc. sg.) and *Die* (fem. sg. / pl.) are possible (cf. Section 3.2.2).

- (1) a. Der mit dem Fön diskutiert: Satiren
lit. ‘(He who) Discusses with the hairdryer: satires’²
(Book title, Winfried Hammelmann 2008)
- b. Die mit dem Bauch tanzen
lit. ‘(Those who) Dance with the belly’
(Documentary film, Carolin Genreith 2014)
- c. Die mit der Schere zeichnet
lit. ‘(She who) Draws with scissors’
(Newspaper headline SZ, 10 June 2016)

What makes snowclones like [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] particularly interesting is that they appear to follow a circular path of development, starting with a lexicalized title unit (stage 1) which, through frequent modifications by many single language users, gradually evolves a semi-schematic pattern (stage 2), which in turn is almost exclusively used to generate other titles (stage 3). From a discourse-functional perspective, such patterns are characterized by genre specificity, which is reflected in sequential usage preferences that are closely related to the contextual characteristics of their lexicalized counterparts: their prominent text position and their associated titling function.

Although constructionist approaches fundamentally aim to incorporate functional and pragmatic dimensions, the full integration of such discourse-specific parameters – such as genre and text-positioning – as defining features of constructions remains an ongoing challenge (cf. Nikiforidou 2018; Hoffmann & Bergs 2018; Finkbeiner 2022, 2024; Stumpf & Mollica 2024). To address this gap, the aim of this article is to shed light on the development of snowclones that exhibit this particular usage preference as a “title template”, using the German adaptation of the aforementioned film title as an example. To date, despite its prominence and productive nature, this winged word has not yet been subject to comprehensive corpus-based analysis from a constructionist perspective, neither synchronically nor diachronically.³ This is particularly noteworthy since, due to the recent origin of the source expression, the pattern is exceptionally well-suited for outlining the dynamic processes to which fixed multi-word expressions can undergo even within shorter periods of time (cf. Buerki 2019; Stumpf 2025: 233). In this light, the film’s release in German cinemas in 1991 provides a clear starting point from which the pattern’s development can be empirically traced, facilitated by the significant expansion of corpus resources from the 1990s onwards.

The paper is structured as follows: Section 2 briefly discusses the mechanism of modification that triggers the schematization process in question, drawing on constructionist approaches to both linguistic creativity and language change. Building on this theoretical foundation, Section 3 presents the case study, first examining the linguistic features of the German source construction *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt*, arguing that its distinctive syntax, qualified as ‘syntactic haplology’, offers strong recognition value that significantly influences pattern formation (Section 3.1). This is followed by a corpus analysis of the resulting template [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] based on 3,395 instances from the *DeReKo* W archive (Section 3.2) and a subsequent discussion of its snowclone status (Section 3.3). The case study combines

² The translations of the examples deliberately retain the German syntax, rather than adapting to the English structure based on ‘Dances with Wolves’. For an analysis of the syntactic differences between the English original and the German translation, see Section 3.1.

³ Garski (2008: 111) does mention this pattern as “a particularly striking and memorable title template of recent times” (own translation) but presents only ten modifications of the film title, alongside various other examples of creative adaptations of set phrases in newspaper headlines. Further evidence is provided by the Duden dictionary 12 (*Zitate und Aussprüche*), noting that the title is “frequently cited in modified form” (2008: 124, own translation), with examples like *Der mit dem Golf tanzt* ‘(He who) Dances with the Golf’ (a road test of a VW Golf) or *Der mit dem Reck tanzt* ‘(He who) Dances with the horizontal bar’ (about world champion gymnast Florian Hambüchen in 2007). In spite of these references, a systematic and detailed analysis of its productive structure and the processes that led to its formation is still lacking.

synchronic information on productivity and slot-filling restrictions, analyzed with the corpus tool *lexpan*, and diachronic evidence from timeline graphs. Together, these data demonstrate how the occasional use of the title unit develops over time into a partly schematic construction that is primarily used in title contexts, especially as ‘topic headlines’ in newspaper articles. Section 4 explores this genre specificity in detail, with a focus on contextual entrenchment as the key mechanism underlying its emergence to a productive title template in German. Section 5 then summarizes the results and points to open questions that could be fruitful areas for future research.

2. Constructional idioms through the lens of creativity and language change: the case of snowclones

In recent years, so-called constructional idioms (henceforth CIs) have gained considerable prominence in contemporary linguistics, particularly in Construction Grammar and phraseological research, where they have even come to be regarded as the central nexus for the growing convergence of these two research traditions (cf. Stutz & Finkbeiner 2022: 287–288; Mellado Blanco & Ivorra Ordines 2023: 28). According to Booij (2002: 302), CIs can be understood as “syntactic constructions with a (partially or fully) noncompositional meaning contributed by the construction, in which – unlike idioms in the traditional sense – only a subset (possibly empty) of the terminal elements is fixed.” This characterization distinguishes CIs from traditional idioms by highlighting their hybrid nature: while certain components function as fixed anchors, others serve as productive slots that speakers must renew in the discourse according to specific communicative needs as well as different (semantic) restrictions or preferences of use (cf. Dobrovol’skij 2011: 114; Mellado Blanco in press).

The interest in semi-schematic patterns was already present in early constructionist work during the 1980s, where they were initially examined as “formal or lexically open idioms” (Fillmore, Kay & O’Connor 1988). Since then, such patterns have been studied under various labels, including “schematic idioms” (Croft & Cruse 2004) or “Phrasem-Konstruktionen” ‘phrase constructions’ (Dobrovol’skij 2011) in constructionist frameworks, and “Modellbildungen” ‘model formations’ (Häusermann 1977) or “Phrasedoschablonen” ‘phraseological templates’ (Fleischer 1997) in German phraseological tradition (for an overview see, e.g., Mellado Blanco, Mollica & Schafroth 2022: 2). Their theoretical significance is closely related to their position on the lexicon-grammar continuum, which is one of the fundamental tenets of Construction Grammar (cf. Croft & Cruse 2004: 255f; Ziem & Lasch 2013: Chapter 8.1). Since CIs are partially schematic from a grammatical perspective and partially specialized from a lexical standpoint, they occupy a middle ground within this continuum, exhibiting characteristics of both ends of the spectrum. This intermediate position explains why CIs have catalyzed interdisciplinary interest, challenging the traditional focus of phraseology on fixedness while providing Construction Grammar with concrete evidence for gradience between lexical and grammatical knowledge (cf. Ziem 2018: 6–7; Ivorra Ordines 2022: 31–33). This theoretical bridge has inspired extensive research, especially in German linguistics, where CIs now serve as a central testing ground for the convergence of phraseological and constructionist perspectives (see, among others, Ziem 2018; Mellado Blanco 2022; Mellado Blanco, Mollica & Schafroth 2022; Finkbeiner 2017, 2022; Mollica & Stumpf 2022; Stumpf 2022).

As Mellado Blanco (in press) notes, the flourishing scholarly attention to CIs is now reflected in a substantial body of studies that address a wide range of aspects. These include, above all, creativity and linguistic innovation (e.g., Sampson 2016; Bergs 2019), conventionalization and social dimensions (e.g., Schmid 2020; Merten 2024; Ivorra Ordines & Mellado Blanco 2025), pragmatic functions (e.g., Finkbeiner 2019a, 2019b, 2022), as well as genre-specific applications and usage contexts (e.g., Nikiforidou & Fischer 2015; Hoffmann & Bergs 2018; Stumpf & Stein (eds.) 2024). Among these perspectives, the focus on creativity is particularly relevant as it raises a crucial question that shifts our focus from synchronic to diachronic analysis. While usage-based Construction Grammar has traditionally adopted a predominantly synchronic perspective (cf. Goldberg 2006: 45–48; Noël 2007:

2), its application to diachronic research is a relatively recent development (cf., e.g., Noël & Coleman 2021; Ziem 2023). However, as scholarly interest in the historical evolution of constructions continues to grow, two distinct yet interconnected questions become central for current research on CIs: The first concerns, at a synchronic level, which constructions of this kind actually exist in a language and how they can be systematically identified, described, and documented in a repository⁴. The second addresses, from the perspective of language change, the processes and mechanisms through which CIs emerge and become established in the linguistic system (see also Stumpf 2025: 197–198).

In order to address the latter issue, it is fruitful to examine creativity as one of the driving forces behind linguistic innovation. For a phenomenon to be considered creative in general, common definitions agree that it must exhibit two essential characteristics, which Simonton (2012) describes as interacting features: novelty/originality and appropriateness (see also Kaufman 2016: 5; Hoffmann 2022: 260). Creativity in language, according to Leech (1969: 24), can manifest either in making “original use of the established possibilities of language” or by creating “new communicative possibilities which are not already in the language”. Sampson (2016) builds on this distinction with his concepts of ‘F-creativity’ (fixed creativity) and ‘E-creativity’ (enlarging/extending creativity) which have recently attracted considerable attention in Construction Grammar research: whereas the former involves the rule-governed extension of existing schemas, the latter encompasses innovative language uses that transcend the current system, potentially generating entirely new schemas. From a Construction Grammar perspective, F-creativity thus manifests when existing constructions fully or partially license new tokens (“structure shapes use”, Norde & Trousdale 2024: 31), thus aligning closely with linguistic productivity as described by Barðdal (2008). E-creativity, in contrast, emerges when speakers generalize over tokens that violate established patterns, which reflects their ability “to go beyond their existing constructional possibilities” (Hoffmann 2022: 266) and may result in novel forms (“use shapes structure”, Norde & Trousdale 2024: 31). As repeated acts of rule violations (E-creativity) can eventually develop to new conventional schemas (F-creativity) through a process of type entrenchment (Taylor 2002: 274–277), F- and E-creativity represent, as Bergs (2019: 182) aptly points out, “a cline, rather than a dichotomy”.

According to Bergs (2018: 280), one particularly significant form of creative behavior in the sense of E-creativity consists in the “intentional manipulation of linguistic material”, most clearly reflected in what phraseology refers to as “modification” (Burger 2015: 159–178), i.e. the occasional, deliberate variation of fixed multi-word expressions to achieve specific communicative or stylistic effects (cf. Ptashnyk 2009; Jaki 2014). This phenomenon is very widespread in everyday life, as evident in examples from advertising and literature, cf. (2)–(5).

- (2) *Fun, Forrest, Fun*. Mach mit beim #Klimai und spar CO2! (‘Fun, Forrest, Fun. Join the #Klimai and save CO2’)
(Advertising by the German electricity and gas provider *Yello-Strom*, 2023)
- (3) *Born to be mild*.
(Advertising by the German chocolate brand *Rittersport*, 2020)
- (4) *Je ne raclette rien!* 70 internationale Rezepte zum Dahinschmelzen (‘Je ne raclette rien! 70 international recipes to melt away’)
(Cookbook title of Maria Panzer, Michael Fischer Publishing 2019)

⁴ For German, two repositories are of particular relevance in this context, as they incorporate CIs more or less systematically: (1) *The German FrameNet-Constructicon* (<https://framenet-constructicon.hhu.de/>), which documents constructions of various types in a network structure, with CIs accounting for roughly 130 of more than 600 published entries (status: 31 October 2025); (2) *PhraConRep* (‘Phraseme Constructions Repository’, <https://www.phraconrep.com/>), developed within the European COST-Action CA22115, which is dedicated to CIs from a learner-oriented perspective and currently comprises over 300 candidates in ongoing publication. While reflecting the growing interest in mid-level constructions, both repositories are still primarily synchronic in orientation and do not systematically address diachronic aspects of constructional emergence and development.

- (5) *Ich lenke, also bin ich*. Bekenntnisse eines überzeugten Radfahrers ('I steer, therefore I am. Confessions of a convinced cyclist')
(Book title of Kai Schächtele, Heyne Publishing 2012)

Modifications such as those in examples (2)–(5) share a defining feature: native speakers are expected to recognize an underlying lexicalized source expression in which certain elements have been replaced by contextually relevant words – a prominent modification technique known as ‘lexical substitution’ (Burger 2015: 164; Ptashnyk 2009: 82–89). Furthermore, in these examples, the substitutes retain a phonetic similarity to the original elements through rhyme, assonance, or shared onset, which further reinforces immediate and reliable recognition: *fun* instead of *run* in (2), *mild* instead of *wild* in (3), *raclette* instead of *regrette* in (4), and *lenke* (‘steer’) instead of *denke* (‘think’) in (5).

As Philip (2008: 104) observes, this dual presence of the original and modified form creates a distinctive cognitive effect: like a palimpsest where earlier writing remains visible beneath newer text, the source expression always “shines through” the modification. This palimpsestic quality allows modification to function as an ‘allusion technique’ (Stein 1995: 250), frequently used in mass media (cf. e.g., Bass 2006; Sakowski 2017), whose communicative impact depends entirely on recipients’ successful recognition of the phraseological source. In this way, modification manifests as a rich intertextual phenomenon, activating something established and recognizable, yet reshaping it into something new (cf. Jaki 2014: 52).

While traditional phraseology has conceptualized modifications as “ad-hoc formations” (Ágel 2004: 67) or “momentary formations” (‘Augenblicksbildungen’, Bebermeyer & Bebermeyer 1977: 1) – viewing them as occasional phenomena that are restricted to the level of *parole* with no systematic impact on the language system – Construction Grammar reinterprets these creative forms as potential drivers of language change (cf. Mellado Blanco 2022: 12–13). In fact, while some expressions are modified just once or twice for specific situations, others are exploited as real substitutive patterns through regular series of variations, sometimes becoming more frequent than the original form itself (cf. Stumpf 2016). Corpus analysis provides compelling evidence for this systematic dimension, as illustrated by example (5), the German adaptation of René Descartes’ famous quote *Ich denke, also bin ich* ‘I think, therefore I am’. A corpus search in the *German Reference Corpus* reveals that this quotation appears in its original wording in only 24.5% of the cases (599/2,444 tokens), while the vast majority (75.5%, 1,845 tokens) features modifications at the first verb position, with a total of 577 different substitutes such as *kaufe* ‘buy’, *arbeite* ‘work’, *shoppe* ‘shop’, or *träume* ‘dream’.

By identifying the underlying systematics of such seemingly unique deviations, revealing “the regular in the irregular” (Ziem 2018: 8, own translation), it becomes clear that creative modifications, though not precisely predictable, typically follow recognizable trends of variation, often motivated by phonological, semantic, and/or morphological links to the substituted elements (cf. Rasulic 2010; Stutz 2024: 264–300). From this perspective, although those single creative acts may seem irrelevant in isolation, their cumulative number and diversity can exert an influence at the systemic level by initiating a schematization process that may lead to the emergence of a new idiom with conceptual slot positions, such as [*Ich X, also bin ich*] ‘I X, therefore I am’, concerning the Descartes quotation. In this sense, the collective creative use of fixed idioms through recurrent modifications can indeed prove to be a real “trigger for the emergence of new semi-schematic constructions” (Mellado Blanco 2022: 12), whose scope and dynamics are still far from being fully understood.

Against this background, such patterns resulting from collective modifications have recently been discussed with growing intensity under the label of “snowclones”, a term originally coined by Pullum (2004) in the context of blog and journalism.⁵ It refers to “some-assembly-required adaptable cliché frames” for writers that gives rise to several variations on the same pattern, often employed with a

⁵ For a comprehensive history of the term and its investigation specifically within Construction Grammar, see Hartmann & Ungerer (2024: 600–602).

playful or humorous intention (cf. Bergs 2019: 177). Taking a constructionist approach, Hartmann & Ungerer (2024) see snowclones as a specific subtype of CIs (see also Sailer 2013) that, beyond their shared semi-schematicity, exhibit two additional distinctive characteristics: First, while snowclones consist of both fixed elements and variable positions like other CIs, they are distinguished by the fact that they “arise from inserting variable lexical slots into previously fixed patterns” (Hartmann & Ungerer 2024: 601), which presupposes the existence of a concrete source expression⁶. Second, snowclones exhibit formal and/or functional traits that align with what Haspelmath (1999: 1057) characterized as “extravagance” – a concept referring to the speakers’ tendency to “talk in such a way that you are noticed” (see Keller 2003, cf. also Eitelmann & Haumann 2022). As extravagance often manifests as deliberate deviations from linguistic norms that enhance the pattern’s memorability (cf. Ungerer & Hartmann 2020), this perfectly aligns with the phenomenon of serial modification discussed in this paper as instances of rule-breaking E-creativity, offering an explanation for why language users are E-creative in the first place. This is consistent with the observation that snowclones are particularly widespread in attention-driven textual genres such as press language and advertising (cf. Hartmann & Ungerer 2024: 629), where their extravagant nature serves the communicative goal of standing out in competitive discourse environments (see Section 4).

Connecting snowclones to broader models of language change, their evolution can be effectively conceptualized as a ‘phenomenon of the third kind’ in Keller’s (2003) sense, a process driven by shared collective communicative needs rather than intentional individual actions (see also Croft 2000: 59–62; Ziem 2023: 11–12). As Hoffmann (2022: 262) argues, significant linguistic innovations typically result from accumulated small-scale changes made unconsciously by individual speakers, which spread throughout a speech community before being recognized as substantial (cf. Schmid 2020; Traugott & Trousdale 2013). This process, “*initiated* by members of the speech community but not *intended* by them” (Ziem 2023: 12, own translation and emphasis), demonstrates that speakers do not operate as isolated creative islands (each engaging in ‘one-off modifications’), but rather as participants in collective linguistic evolution (jointly producing systematic change through cumulative modification).

In constructional terms, this process can be captured through the notion of “constructionalization” (Traugott & Trousdale 2013: 22), a concept referring to the creation of new form-meaning pairings within the linguistic system. While linguistic innovations hardly ever arise *ex nihilo*, the emerging constructions in our case systematically build on pre-existing forms, developing through analogical extensions from fixed phraseological items. As a result, new type nodes emerge and gradually become integrated into the constructional network through a dual process of formal and semantic abstraction: the formal changes manifest in the development of slot positions, while simultaneously, the meaning of the source construction generalizes (cf. Traugott & Trousdale 2013: 183). Together, these developments result in a constructional set with distinct but related constructions displaying varying degrees of schematicity (cf. Traugott 2008: 236; Traugott & Trousdale 2010: 28).

Given that the micro-steps of constructionalization remain largely imperceptible on a synchronic level, the methodological challenge for diachronically oriented constructionist research lies in systematically identifying such usage events whose form and function show systematic similarity, signaling the onset of a schematization process. In previous research, constructional idioms in general as well as snowclones in particular have mostly been described from a product-oriented rather than a process-oriented perspective (cf. Stumpf 2016: 338), based primarily on synchronic corpus data that capture productivity and schematicity aspects across an entire corpus, resulting in a merely ‘panchronic’ perspective that fails to account for diachronic dynamics. As recently noted by Stumpf (2025: 206), this limitation calls for micro-diachronic analyses of subcorpora to trace constructional development in greater detail. Building on this observation, I propose an additional methodological approach, outlined in Section 3: the

⁶ For a critical discussion of this feature from an entrenchment-based perspective, see Stumpf (2025), who provides empirical evidence from online survey data showing that source recognition varies considerably among speakers and that knowledge of origins can be lost over time within the speech community.

implementation of timeline graphs (“Zeitverlaufsgrafiken”, Längen & Keibel 2014), which systematically track and contrast the development of conventional versus occasional phraseme realizations across annual corpus slices. As will be shown, this method not only enables a more fine-grained reconstruction of the gradual emergence of constructional schemas but also provides empirical insights into shifts in slot-filling restrictions over time, shedding light on how constructional patterns stabilize and evolve within the linguistic system.

That being said, the effectiveness of such diachronic analyses crucially depends on the availability of sufficient diachronically layered corpus data spanning longer periods of time. While patterns such as [*Ich X, also bin ich*] ‘I X, therefore I am’ are generally assumed to have developed through modifications of lexically fixed units, this key criterion often remains non-verifiable owing to limited diachronic corpus coverage that would allow us to trace their development back to their presumed lexical origin (sometimes dating back several centuries, as in the case of Descartes’ dictum from the mid-1600s). However, more recent units – particularly those that emerged after 1990 – offer a distinct methodological advantage: thanks to the steadily increasing coverage of large-scale corpora such as the *German Reference Corpus* (DeReKo), whose W archive provides the empirical basis for the present study, their trajectories of use can be reconstructed in far greater detail (cf. Figure 1).

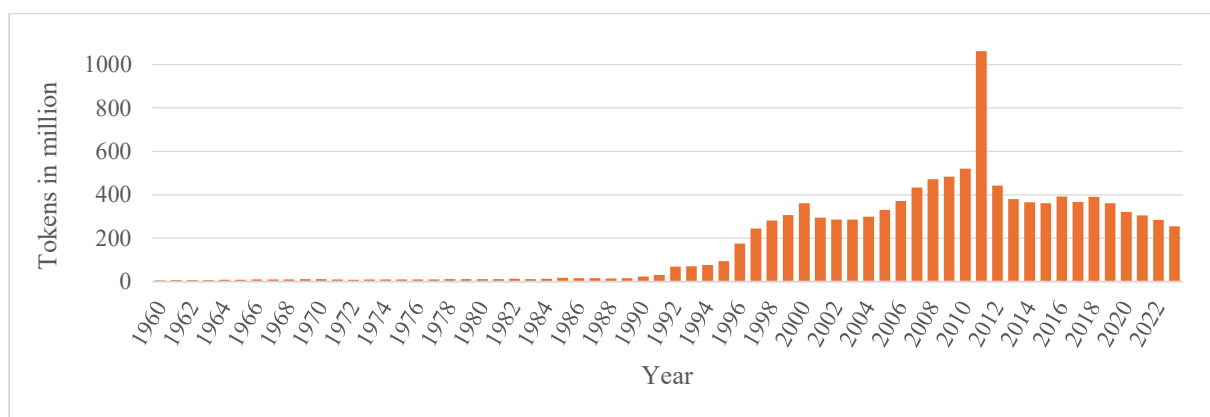


Figure 1: Corpus presentation of the *DeReKo* W archive (public), excerpt from 1960 to 2023

Such younger items not only make it possible to observe the dynamics of pattern formation processes with greater empirical precision, but they also provide a testing ground for addressing the still unresolved ‘chicken-or-egg-question’ in this context: What came first, the lexical or the schematic construction? A question that is far from trivial, as in Construction Grammar terms, it directly concerns the nature of inheritance link that exists between these constructions within a network structure – specifically, whether these links are to be modeled as ‘instance links’ (Goldberg 1995: 79–81) or as ‘generalization links’⁷ (Mollica 2018: 218). Against this backdrop, diachronic work on snowclones becomes an absolute priority: firstly, to provide empirical evidence that snowclones indeed originate from specific source expressions, and secondly, to gain a better understanding of how they gradually emancipate themselves from their lexical bases even over relatively short periods of time.

Summing up this section, the interplay between modification and constructionalization illuminates the inherently fluid nature of linguistic creativity, reflected in the gradual transition from E- to F-creativity: what begins as occasional variation can, through repeated similar usage, incrementally develop into a new productive schema. Modification, as a source of creativity, thus operates along a formulaic-creative continuum, sometimes remaining as isolated norm deviation, but at other times triggering schematization processes that generate new CIs. The methodological framework outlined above, centered on diachronically layered corpus investigation, provides the empirical means necessary to trace

⁷ Generalization links (‘Generalisierung-von-Beziehungen’, Mollica 2018: 218) describe cases where a specific construction serves as the starting point for the formation of a more schematic one, with the latter inheriting its characteristic formal and functional features from its source.

these emergent patterns systematically. The following case study demonstrates this approach by presenting a corpus-based diachronic analysis of a relatively recent snowclone in contemporary German that derives from a well-known film title: *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* (orig. *Dances with wolves*).

3. Tracing snowclones: a case study

In this Section, I examine the snowclone status of *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* and trace its pattern formation process in detail. To accomplish this, the analysis first explores the unique linguistic characteristics of the film title itself (Section 3.1), before conducting a corpus-based analysis of the pattern [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}], investigating its productivity and diachronic development (Section 3.2).

3.1 General traits of the source construction – a case of ‘syntactic haplogy’?

Der mit dem Wolf tanzt is the German title of the US-American film adaptation of Michael Blake’s novel *Dances with Wolves*, which was released in German cinemas in 1991. As the title of a highly successful, Oscar-winning film, which ranked among the top-grossing releases worldwide in 1990/91⁸, the expression gained widespread recognition and was even included in the third edition (2008) of the Duden collection 12 *Zitate und Aussprüche* (‘Quotes and sayings’) where it was given the status of a “winged word” – a quotation-like expression characterized by the reminiscence of its origin and the corresponding source awareness in the linguistic collective (cf. Burger 2015: 48; Duden 2008: 11–12; see also Stein 2024 for a critical discussion of this concept). The title refers to the film’s protagonist, Union Army Lieutenant John Dunbar, who is transferred to a remote military outpost in the frontier during the American Civil War, earning this name from the local Sioux Indians after they observe him playfully interacting with a wild wolf. Ultimately, *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* functions on two levels: as the name of the protagonist within the narrative and as the title of both the novel and its film adaptation.

While proper names are typically limited to a referential function (cf. Nübling 2012: 17), *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* contains descriptive content motivated by a distinctive characteristic of its bearer. It describes an anthropomorphic action (‘dancing’) performed with a wild animal (‘wolf’), thus creating a combination so extraordinary that it serves as a unique identifier throughout the narrative. In this way, the descriptive phrase becomes exclusively associated with him as referent, thus exemplifying as case of “onymization”, i.e. the transformation of a descriptive phrase into a monoreferential linguistic symbol (cf. Nübling 2012: 16). This classifies the expression as belonging to a category of proper names that fulfills referential function by designating unique features without containing a conventional proper noun (cf. Kempf, Nübling, & Schmuck 2020: 1–2; Schlücker & Ackermann 2017: 310–312).

Beyond its distinctive descriptive content, *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* also stands out in formal terms. This becomes evident when comparing the Native American character names in the English original with those of the German film translation (cf. Table 1): While all names were translated literally, the protagonist’s was not – in German, he is not called *Tanzt mit Wölfen* (lit. ‘Dances with wolves’) but *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* (lit. ‘He who dances with the wolf’). Apart from the shift from plural to singular in *wolf*⁹, the German translation differs primarily in syntactic structure, introducing an initial pronoun (*der*), which in turn leads to an alteration in word order (verb-final instead of verb-first). This transformation is particularly striking, because other verb-initial names such as *Stands with a fist* and *Smiles a lot* were translated literally (*Steht mit einer Faust*, *Lächelt viel*), even though structurally parallel options with initial pronouns and altered verb placement would have been possible as well: *Die mit einer Faust steht* (lit. ‘She who stands with a fist’) and *Der viel lächelt* (‘He who smiles a lot’). The German version thus deliberately deviates from a literal translation in this case alone, creating a distinct

⁸ Box Office Mojo: *Dances with Wolves* (1990) – Worldwide Gross (original release): approx. USD 184.2 million (<https://www.boxofficemojo.com/title/tt0099348/> [23 September 2025]).

⁹ The choice of singular *Wolf* ‘wolf’ over plural *Wölfe* ‘wolves’ in the German title is not entirely transparent, but is likely phonetically motivated as the monosyllabic nature of *Wolf* creates a more balanced rhythmic structure through entirely strong single-syllable elements (*Der – mit – dem – Wolf – tanzt*).

stylistic and syntactic profile that sets the protagonist apart and simultaneously foregrounds the eponymous film title.¹⁰

Name in English	German translation	Translation equivalent not selected
<i>Dances with wolves</i>	<i>Der mit dem Wolf tanzt</i>	<i>Tanzt mit dem Wolf</i> (lit. ‘Dances with the wolf’)
<i>Kicking bird</i>	<i>Strampelnder Vogel</i>	
<i>Wind in his hair</i>	<i>Wind in seinem Haar</i>	
<i>Stands with a fist</i>	<i>Steht mit einer Faust</i>	<i>Die mit einer Faust steht</i> (lit. ‘She who stands with a fist’)
<i>Smiles a lot</i>	<i>Lächelt viel</i>	<i>Der viel lächelt</i> (lit. ‘He who smiles a lot’)
<i>Ten Bears</i>	<i>Zehn Bären</i>	
<i>Pretty Shield</i>	<i>Schöner Schild</i>	
<i>Black Shawl</i>	<i>Schwarzer Schal</i>	
<i>Stone Calf</i>	<i>Steinkalb</i>	
<i>Otter</i>	<i>Otter</i>	

Table 1: Native American character names in the film, English original and German translation

While the syntactic structure chosen for the German title can be considered unusual and striking, it seems not to be confined to this western alone but rather to follow an established pattern in German film title adaptations, as shown by earlier examples such as (6)–(9)¹¹.

- (6) *Die mit der Liebe spielen* (1961), orig. *L’avventura* (Italian)
lit. ‘Those who play with love’
- (7) *Die mit den Wölfen heulen* (1968), orig. *The Hell with Heroes* (English)
lit. ‘Those who howl with wolves’
- (8) *Der aus dem Regen kam* (1970), orig. *Le Passager de la pluie* (French)
lit. ‘He who came out of the rain’
- (9) *Die durch die Hölle gehen* (1978), orig. *The Deer Hunter* (English)
lit. ‘Those who go through hell’

These examples illustrate that literal translations were consistently avoided in favor of the unified structural pattern [DER Prep N_{dat} V_{fin}] (lit. ‘The one/Those who V_{fin} Prep NP’). Years later, this formula was replicated for the Costner film, with the unique twist that the expression functions both as an anthroponym within the narrative and as an ergonym for the cinematic work as a whole. More fundamentally, though, its onomastic potential can only be fully understood against the background of its syntactic configuration, which merits closer examination.

Indeed, the syntactic status of *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* is far from clear. At first glance, the expression exhibits formal characteristics of a subordinate clause: it is introduced by the d-pronoun *der* in complementizer position and follows German subordinate clause word order with the finite verb in final position. Notably, however, the expression appears syntactically independent, functioning autonomously without an overt superordinate reference noun. This suggests the absence of a matrix element, for which the demonstrative pronoun *der* seems the most plausible candidate, semantically similar to the cataphoric form *derjenige* (‘the one’) in German, as illustrated in (10).

¹⁰ At the same time, it can be assumed that this choice was made to dispel the marked character of the English title, which is itself ambiguous: *dances* can be read either as a finite verb form (*He/She dances with wolves*), a fairly marked reading that is relevant in the context of the film, or as an entirely unmarked noun-preposition-noun construction with *dances* as a plural noun (*Dances with Wolves* = ‘Tänze mit Wölfen’). As this kind of ambiguity cannot arise in German (*tanzt* vs. *Tänze*), the German title resorts to a different, equally marked construction with an initial pronoun and verb-final word order.

¹¹ Beyond examples requiring a preposition in second position, this free relative clause structure appears in even more German film titles, such as *Die den Tod nicht fürchten* (*The Wreck of the Mary Deare*, 1959) or *...die keine Gnade kennen* (*Raid on Entebbe*, 1976). I thank my colleague Stefan Hartmann for this observation.

- (10) a. (**Der**,) **der** mit dem Wolf tanzt
 ‘He who dances with the wolf’
 b. (**Derjenige**,) **der** mit dem Wolf tanzt
 ‘The one who dances with the wolf’

This structure closely resembles the free relative clauses with d-pronouns discussed by Fuß & Grewendorf (2014: 166), who provide examples such as (11). According to the authors, such constructs are essentially regular restrictive relative clauses where the relative pronoun is omitted because it would be morphologically identical to the demonstrative d-pronoun serving as reference element:

- (11) a. **Der den Tod auf Hiroshima warf**, ging ins Kloster, läutet dort die Glocken.
 [Der, [~~der~~ den Tod auf Hiroshima warf]] ...)
 lit. ‘The one who threw death at Hiroshima went to the monastery and rang the bells there.’
 b. **Die das nicht so gut können**, fliegen raus.
 [Die, [~~die~~ das nicht so gut können]], fliegen raus.
 lit. ‘Those who are not so good at it are thrown out.’

In this analysis, such reduced structures are treated as instances of ‘syntactic haplology’. While the term ‘haplology’ traditionally refers to a phonetic dissimilation process in which formally identical and neighboring syllables or phonemes are reduced to a single occurrence (e.g., **Zaubererin* > *Zaubererin* ‘sorceress’), syntactic haplology occurs at the word level. In this case, the reduction affects free morphemes with similar grammatical features that share the same form and stand in a direct local relationship (see, among others, Neeleman & van de Koot 2006; Nevins 2012):

- (12) ... M₁ M₂ ... → ... ~~M₁~~ M₂ ... or ... M₁ ~~M₂~~ ... (cf. Fuß & Grewendorf 2014: 189)

The analogy to the *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* and the other title units in (6)–(9) is obvious: All these cases follow the same principle, involving a d-pronoun that would normally appear twice in immediate succession, hence inviting omission:

- (13) a. [~~Der~~, **der** mit dem Wolf tanzt]
 b. [**Der**, [~~der~~ mit dem Wolf tanzt]]

While it remains unclear which of the two d-elements is actually omitted¹², this ambiguity contributes to the structure’s distinctive character, resulting in the fused form *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt*. An alternative analysis is to assume that the omitted matrix element is a noun phrase consisting of a head noun and the definite article *der*, cf. (14). This would imply the deletion of the entire NP, which could be explained by the presence of another element in the German expression – although not immediately adjacent – that formally coincides with the relative pronoun, namely the definite article *der*.

- (14) [[~~Der Mann~~], **der** mit dem Wolf tanzt]
 ‘The man who dances with the wolf’

The question of which of the two proposed analyses applies here cannot be answered conclusively – and it is hardly necessary. In fact, the unresolved status contributes to its special appeal making it highly distinctive and memorable precisely through its deviation from common German syntax. In this respect,

¹² The substitution test suggests that deletion of the demonstrative pronoun is more likely, as expressions like **Jener mit dem Wolf tanzt* or **Dieser mit dem Wolf tanzt* are ungrammatical in German – indicating that other demonstratives cannot substitute for the missing element. At the same time, the relative pronoun seems to absorb the function of the demonstrative, which remains latently present due to formal identity. Crucially, the semantic properties of the deleted element – demonstrative pronouns being inherently definite (cf. Fuß & Grewendorf 2014: 193) – thus persist, allowing the expression to be interpreted as a definite designation, or “denoting phrase” in Russell’s (1905) sense.

the construction represents a peculiarity of the German language¹³, behaving like what Pittner (1995: 195) terms a “disguised relative clause” (‘verkappter Attributsatz’), a complex noun phrase with a relative structure where the omission creates the impression of “insubordination” (Evans 2007), referring to the syntactically independent use of a syntactically dependent unit. As a result, this makes the structure appear “extra-grammatical” in the sense of Fillmore, Kay & O’Connor (1988: 505), as it does not conform to standard syntactic rules.

The striking linguistic form of the German title not only ensures a high level of recognition, but has also inspired numerous variations, allowing it to be creatively reused across various contexts by replacing several elements at once. As evident from the examples already mentioned in (1), repeated below, three key elements seem to be regularly modified: the initial d-pronoun, the NP following the preposition *mit* ‘with’, and the finite verb in final position.

- (1) a. Der mit dem Fön diskutiert: Satiren
lit. ‘(He who) Discusses with the hairdryer: satires’
- b. Die mit dem Bauch tanzen
lit. ‘(Those who) Dance with the belly’
- c. Die mit der Schere zeichnet
lit. ‘(She who) Draws with scissors’

This lexical flexibility indicates the emergence of a productive pattern with the form [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] ‘The one/Those who V_{fin} with NP_{dat}’, characterized by the consistent absence of a matrix element. To examine how frequent such modifications actually are and whether the pattern qualifies as a construction on its own right, the next section presents an in-depth corpus analysis. The aim is to combine quantitative dimensions – particularly concerning its (synchronic) productivity and the diachronic development of modifications over the last 35 years – with qualitative insights into slot restrictions and their diachronic shifts. In doing so, the analysis seeks to validate the pattern’s snowclone status by providing clear evidence of its derivation from the film title and its subsequent development along the classic progression from E-creativity to F-creativity.

3.2 On the snowclone status of [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}]: a diachronic and corpus-based analysis

3.2.1 Data and methods

The following corpus study is based on the W archive of the *German Reference Corpus* (DeReKo, release w-public-2024-I)¹⁴. Beyond its comprehensive size (approximately 11.2 billion words), which is crucial for analyzing low-frequency items such as CIs (cf. Ivorra Ordines 2022: 37), it was selected for its particularly rich representation of newspaper texts (see Perkuhn 2022: 142–143). This is especially advantageous for the present study, as journalistic texts quickly and vividly reflect linguistic trends (cf. Lüger 2011: 22; Polajnar 2019: 16), suggesting a higher occurrence of modifications. Furthermore, given that the investigated pattern occurs disproportionately often in headline contexts (see Section 4), a corpus with a strong focus on newspaper texts like the chosen one can be expected to yield a sufficient number of relevant instances.

¹³ In contrast, the original English title *Dances with Wolves* as well as several translations in Romance languages (e.g., French *Danse avec les loups*, Spanish *Bailando con lobos* or Italian *Balla coi lupi*) render the expression with verb-initial structures rather than a relative clause, as in German. Whether employing finite indicative forms (French, Italian) or a gerundive structure (Spanish), all these variants share the absence of a relative construction. Since relative pronouns in these languages are morphologically distinct from demonstratives and definite articles, there is no structural motivation for haplological reduction of the kind that gives rise to the German form.

¹⁴ Accessible via COSMAS II: <https://cosmas2.ids-mannheim.de/cosmas2-web/> (30 August 2024).

Since the W archive lacks part-of-speech annotation, a semi-automatic approach was adopted. Relevant instances were retrieved with a query designed to detect cases where a d-pronoun (capitalized, thus sentence-initial) is followed by the preposition *mit* ‘with’, which in turn precedes a definite article in the dative case.¹⁵ The resulting hits were manually checked to remove false positives, which mainly fell into two groups: (i) attestations completely outside the target pattern, such as complex NPs with participial modifiers expanded by a PP (see example 15) or syntactically disintegrated NPs with PP attributes (see example 16); and (ii) structurally deviant relative clauses, including ‘common’ ones with anaphoric reference to an antecedent in covert embedding (see example 17) or free relative clauses with d-pronouns as described in Fuß & Grewendorf 2014 (see example 18). After this filtering, the final data set comprised 3,395 instances, which form the empirical basis for the subsequent analysis.

- (15) **Die mit dem Umbau verbesserten Arbeitsplätze** entschädigten die mühsamen letzten Wochen. (SGT, 30 June 1997)
 ‘The improved workplaces resulting from the renovation compensated for the arduous last few weeks.’
- (16) **Der mit dem Ruhepuls:** Kroos kann Geschichte schreiben (HAZ, 26 May 2018)
 ‘The one with the resting heart rate: Kroos can make history’
- (17) Aber sie sieht einen veränderten Mann. **Der mit den Kindern bastelt. Der mit ihr abends ausgeht.** (Die Zeit online, 11 December 2003)
 ‘But she sees a changed man. Who does handicrafts with the children. Who goes out with her in the evenings.’
- (18) Das Motto ist einfach: laufen, passen, schießen. **Die mit dem Ball jonglieren,** gehören in den Zirkus. (KLZ, 27 March 1999)
 ‘The motto is simple: run, pass, shoot. Those who juggle the ball belong in the circus.’

To examine the lexical variation of the attested instances, this study employs slot analyses carried out with the corpus tool “Lexical Pattern Analyzer” (*lexpan*)¹⁶, which was developed in the project *Usuelle Wortverbindungen* ‘multi-word expressions in common usage’ (cf. Steyer & Brunner 2014). *Lexpan* constitutes an effective instrument for reconstructing and exploring pattern formation, as it enables the systematic identification and quantification of lexical fillers within predefined slots of syntagmatic structures through surface-based search queries. Based on large amounts of corpus data, the slot fillers can be clustered according to different parameters, making it possible to determine both absolute and relative frequencies of filler types in proportion to the overall dataset. The outcomes are presented in filler tables, which provide empirical indications of the nature of lexical fillers (with respect to the morphosyntactic and semantic constraints governing their use) as well as the scale of typicality or productivity (cf. Steyer 2011: 230; see also Stutz & Finkbeiner 2022).

However, while slot analyses provide valuable insights into the overall lexical diversity of a pattern, they aggregate the dataset as a whole without differentiating between different time periods. To complement this essentially static view and also capture temporal dynamics in pattern formation processes, this study additionally employs ‘timeline graphs’ (“Zeitverlaufsgrafiken”, cf. Keibel 2009; Lungen & Keibel 2014), with the dataset structured chronologically into annual corpus slices. In contrast to other diachronic approaches using multi-year subcorpora (e.g., Stumpf 2025), the year-by-year segmentation employed in this study affords a level of temporal granularity that offers two methodological advantages: First, it provides an empirically adequate basis for line-graph visualizations, which offer an intuitively accessible view of frequency trends, facilitating direct comparison of multiple

¹⁵ Search query in COSMAS II: (Der oder Die) /+w1:1,s0 \$mit /+w1:1,s0 (\$dem oder \$der oder \$den) (total number of hits: 25,938).

¹⁶ <http://uww.ids-mannheim.de/lexpan/> (20 August 2025).

trajectories within a single diagram. While line graphs visually suggest a continuous curve, they technically represent discrete data points (in this case, all attestations of a given year grouped into a single object). As Polajnar (2019: 69) notes, this representation is methodologically justified only when temporal intervals are sufficiently fine-grained: broader intervals aggregate increasingly heterogeneous data into single points, thereby producing an artefactual sense of continuity that is not empirically given. Second, wider temporal windows not only undermine the linearity of the visual representation but also may conflate distinct phases in a pattern's development into undifferentiated blocks, thereby reducing the temporal sensitivity needed to capture short-term dynamics – such as immediate responses to cultural events – that are central to understanding processes of pattern emergence and diffusion. Originally developed to visualize the temporal development of neologisms, timeline graphs have proven equally effective for examining the dynamics of lexicalized word combinations, as they make visible the rise and decline of modifications in relation to the source expression over time (cf. Stutz 2024 and Polajnar 2019 for case studies and methodological background). Based on relative frequencies measured in instances per million (IpM), which normalize for variations in corpus size and thus ensure comparability across annual corpus segments, timeline graphs provide an effective means of tracing “the life course” of snowclones (Hartmann & Ungerer 2024: 629), addressing especially three key aspects:

- (i) **their emergence:** identifying when and how a snowclone starts to become productive via modification of a specific source construction, by tracing parallel frequency trajectories of canonical and modified realizations to detect potential lead-lag relationships: If a genealogical link exists, the canonical form's curve is expected to temporally precede the rise of modified variants, with productive variation typically surging in immediate response to a spike in the canonical form's circulation. This temporal diagnostic can, in turn, also clarify whether such sources build on pre-existing patterns that they popularize or represent genuinely novel formations.
- (ii) **their spread:** documenting the temporal dynamics of how rapidly modified variants gain ground and eventually outpace the canonical form in frequency – both overall and with respect to individual constituents –, while also tracking shifts in slot-filling properties over time, thus revealing both the quantitative growth and qualitative evolution of the pattern;
- (iii) **their consolidation or eventual decline:** examining whether a pattern achieves lasting stability through recurrent realizations that, over an extended period, consistently rival or even surpass the canonical form in frequency, securing a durable place in the constructional network; or, conversely, when and how rapidly, after an initial surge in frequency, modified variants lose momentum and fade – sometimes burning out as quickly as they flared up, while in other cases resurfacing later in fresh bursts of creative adaptation.

To empirically validate snowclone status in the corpus data, this study combines both analytical approaches in a two-step procedure. First, *lexpan* analyses provide evidence for synchronic productivity by quantifying the lexical diversity within variable slots and determining the proportion of modified versus canonical realizations across the entire dataset. Following Stumpf's (2016: 337) heuristic distinction between “modification patterns” (‘Modifikationsmuster’) and true phraseological schemata (‘Modellbildungen’), which applies a 50% threshold as operational criterion, cases are treated as mere occasional phenomena in this study if the canonical form still dominates the corpus (i.e. accounts for more than half of all tokens), while those in which modified variants outnumber the canonical form are considered potential snowclones, i.e. semi-schematic patterns with regular slot variation that speakers systematically exploit (for a discussion and empirical support of this benchmark, see Stutz & Finkbeiner 2022). Second, timeline graphs provide the crucial diachronic validation by tracing the pattern's developmental trajectory directly back to its lexical source. For a pattern to qualify as a genuine snowclone, the data must reveal a clear genealogical link to that presumed source, which, in this study, is operationalized by three criteria: (1) the temporal co-onset of rising modification frequencies with the circulation of the canonical form, (2) the semantic and syntactic similarity between early fillers and the

replaced source elements, indicating derivation rather than independent formation, and (3) the gradual emancipation from source constraints, visible in the increasing diversity of slot filling over time.

This combined methodology thus operationalizes snowclone status through both synchronic and diachronic criteria, offering an empirically grounded way of tracing the gradual transition from modified idioms to CIs.

3.2.2 Data analysis: productivity and diachronic development

A slot analysis of the dataset revealed significant variation within the pattern structure: Among the 3,395 occurrences, 1,132 different filler types could be identified, resulting in a type-token ratio of 0.33. Notably, these include a high proportion of ‘hapax legomena’ (henceforth hapaxes) – types that occur only once in the corpus – amounting to 871 instances (hapax-token ratio: 0.26). Table 2 presents both the most frequent realizations and selected hapaxes to illustrate the attested range.

Filler	Tokens	%	Filler	Tokens	%
<i>Der mit dem Wolf tanzt</i> ‘(He who) Dances with the wolf’	1,224	36.05	<i>Der mit dem Alligator paddelt</i> ‘(He who) Paddles with the alligator’	1	0.03
<i>Der mit den Pferden spricht</i> ‘(He who) Talks to the horses’	130	3.83	<i>Der mit dem Fuß bügelt</i> ‘(He who) Irons with the foot’	1	0.03
<i>Die mit der Liebe spielen</i> ‘(Those who) Play with the love’	86	2.53	<i>Der mit dem Mörtel malt</i> ‘(He who) Paints with the mortar’	1	0.03
<i>Der mit dem Ball tanzt</i> ‘(He who) Dances with the ball’	60	1.77	<i>Der mit dem Porree kämpft</i> ‘(He who) Fights with the leek’	1	0.03
<i>Die mit dem Bauch tanzen</i> ‘(Those who) Dance with the belly’	42	1.24	<i>Die mit den Hölzern spricht</i> ‘(She who) Talks to the wood’	1	0.03
<i>Der mit der Stimme tanzt</i> ‘(He who) Dances with the voice’	34	1.00	<i>Die mit den Karpfen kuschelt</i> ‘(She who) Cuddles with the carp’	1	0.03
<i>Die mit dem Wolf tanzt</i> ‘(She who) Dances with the wolf’	25	0.74	<i>Die mit den Geschlechtern spielt</i> ‘(She who) Plays with the gender’	1	0.03
<i>Der mit dem Wort tanzt</i> ‘(He who) Dances with the word’	24	0.71	<i>Die mit den Haien tauchen</i> ‘(Those who) Dive with the sharks’	1	0.03
<i>Die mit dem Blut unterschreiben</i> ‘(Those who) Sign with the blood’	21	0.62	<i>Die mit der Stimme lächeln</i> ‘(Those who) Smile with the voice’	1	0.03
<i>Die mit den Wölfen heulen</i> ‘(Those who) Howl with the wolves’	21	0.62	<i>Die mit der Violine flirtet</i> ‘(She who) Flirts with the violin’	1	0.03
...	...	...	...	...	...

Table 2: Top 10 fillers and selected hapaxes for [DER mit NP_{dat} V_{fin}] (1,132 types in total), sorted by frequency

First, regarding the frequency distributions of the fillers, Table 2 indicates that the title appears in its original, unchanged form in 36% of the cases, while in the remaining 64% the title is modified in one way or another. The modification rate thus clearly exceeds the 50% benchmark suggested by Stumpf (2016), providing initial evidence for the development of a productive schema. In addition to this 2:1 ratio of occasional to usual realizations, speakers show a strong preference for modifying several elements simultaneously: in nearly 70% of the cases, two or three positions are changed at the same time, while single modifications account for only 17% (see Figure 3, left). These findings demonstrate that the pattern exhibits considerable flexibility, allowing speakers to adapt it to diverse communicative intentions and contextual demands through three variable positions – operating at both grammatical (pronoun) and lexical levels (NP, V) – that can be exploited independently or in combination.

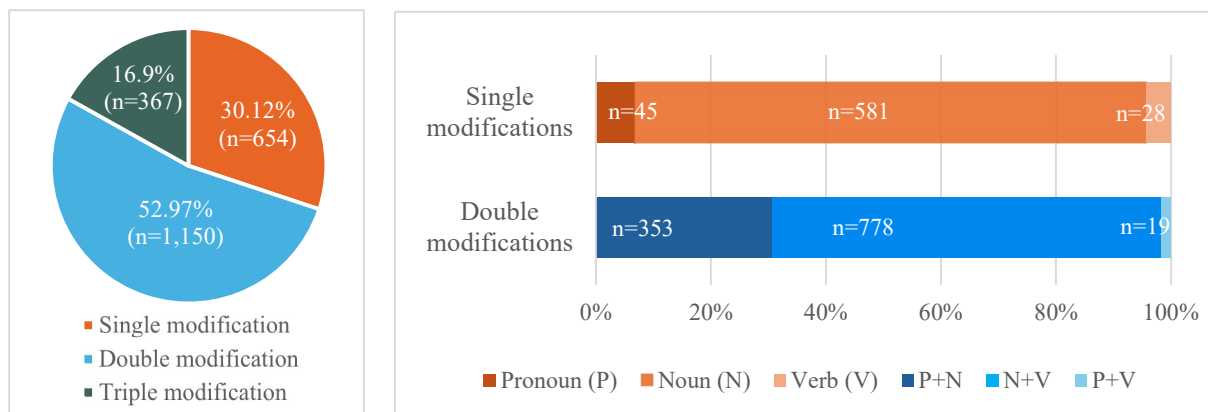


Figure 3: Distribution of modification instances by number of modified elements (left) and by slot type and slot combination (right)

Considered through a diachronic lens, Figure 4 illustrates the temporal evolution of the film title, revealing two key insights: First, the timeline graph provides clear evidence that the expression *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* is indeed a novel creation as it first appears in the corpus only after the film's release in 1991, with no prior attestations. At the same time, the overall corpus data (covering texts from 1960 to 2023) documents that structurally similar instances existed before 1991, though with minimal presence – just five types amounting to 27 tokens. Notably, the vast majority (21 tokens) stem from a single source, the 1961 French film *Die mit der Liebe spielen* previously mentioned in Section 3.1. Taken together, these findings suggest that *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* is an original formation introduced by the film itself, while the syntagmatic structure had already existed before, albeit in a non-productive form.

Second, the timeline graph clearly indicates that it was indeed the film title that contributed to the rapid spread of the pattern in the following years. While the frequency of the title expression steadily declined after its peak in 1991, the occurrence of modified variants increased, surpassing the title's frequency for the first time in 1995 – that is, within the time span of just four years.¹⁷ The fact that afterwards the frequency of variants consistently remained well above that of the film title¹⁸ suggests that this modification trend was not a 'flash in the pan' as is typically observed, for example, in the case of internet memes (cf. Bülow, Merten & Johann 2018) but rather the onset of a schematization process that began shortly after the film's release and, due to its remarkable consistency over almost 30 years, provides strong evidence for a thoroughly established, robust linguistic schema.

¹⁷ Note that the pronounced peak of modified variants in 1998 coincides with the publication of Monty Roberts' biography *Der mit den Pferden spricht* (orig. *The man who listens to horses*), which constitutes a particularly prominent realization of the pattern (see discussion below).

¹⁸ The only exception occurs in 2011, where a brief but notable increase can be attributed to the film's twentieth anniversary with widespread media coverage leading to numerous mentions of the film's title.

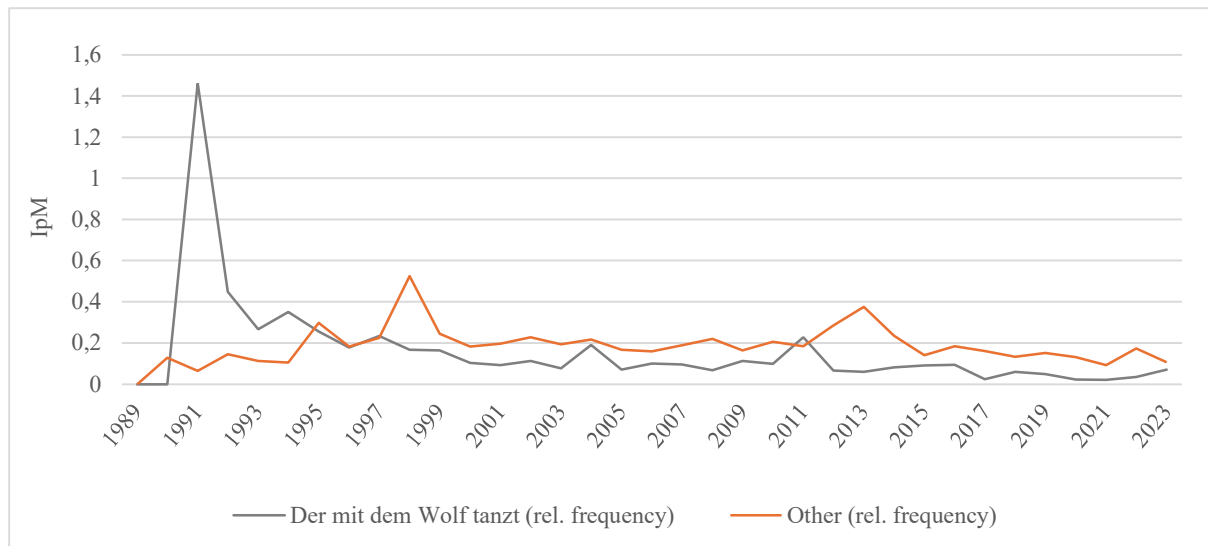


Figure 4: Timeline graph: annual trend of modified vs. unmodified realizations (core phase: 1989–2023, IpM)

Viewed through the lens of creativity and snowclone research (see Section 2), these findings vividly capture a gradual movement along the continuum from E- to F-creativity. While the early modifications clearly represent innovative, non-standard uses of a fixed winged word (E-creativity), showing occasional variations of a popular film title, the year 1995 marks a pivotal point in this process, initiating what can be understood as a transitional stage: At this point, after first exceeding the original expression in frequency and having remained dominant ever since, we can observe a significant advancement toward F-creativity, marking the expression's evolution from sporadic innovative uses to a more systematic pattern that nevertheless remains contextually anchored and largely interpretable against the background of the film title.¹⁹ In this sense, what initially appeared as occasional ad-hoc formations thus began to gradually crystallize into a more entrenched schema of the form [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}], demonstrating how the accumulated effect of independent yet similar creative choices can lead to an unintended systemic outcome – representing a prime example of what Keller (2003) has termed an ‘invisible-hand phenomenon’.

Building on the analysis of the overall pattern, we now turn to an analysis of the individual elements that exhibit systematic variation: (a) the pronoun, (b) the noun (phrase) and (c) the verb. As shown in Figure 5, a closer look at their diachronic development reveals that modifications to all three components appear very shortly after the film's release. However, they differ considerably in their modification rates, suggesting that they do not contribute equally to the pattern's productivity: Across all modified instances, the noun slot emerges as the most prominent locus of creative variation, being modified in approximately 60% of all cases, while verb and pronoun modifications occur to a significantly lesser extent (34% and 36%, respectively). This asymmetry is already evident in *single-slot* modifications (cf. Figure 3, right), where noun changes (n=581) vastly outnumber verb (n=45) and pronoun substitutions (n=28), and becomes even more pronounced in *double-slot* modifications, where the noun is involved in 98% of all cases (noun+verb: n=778; pronoun+noun: n=353). The noun is therefore not only the most frequently modified element but also the component most often involved in complex variants –

¹⁹ This continued anchoring in the film title is evidenced by metalinguistic comments, as example (19) illustrates, demonstrating that speakers – even more than twenty years after modified uses had surpassed the canonical form – consciously recognize and exploit the connection to the source expression by explicitly framing it in relation to the original film context.

(19) Der mit dem Papst tanzt, so lautet der Titel eines Musicals, [...] das in Anlehnung an einen bekannten Hollywoodstreifen ebenso vertraut wie provokativ klingt. (RHZ, 11 February 2017)
 ‘(He who) Dances with the Pope is the title of a musical, [...] which, inspired by a well-known Hollywood film, sounds as familiar as it is provocative.’

suggesting its role as the construction’s creative center, which will be examined in greater detail in the following sections.

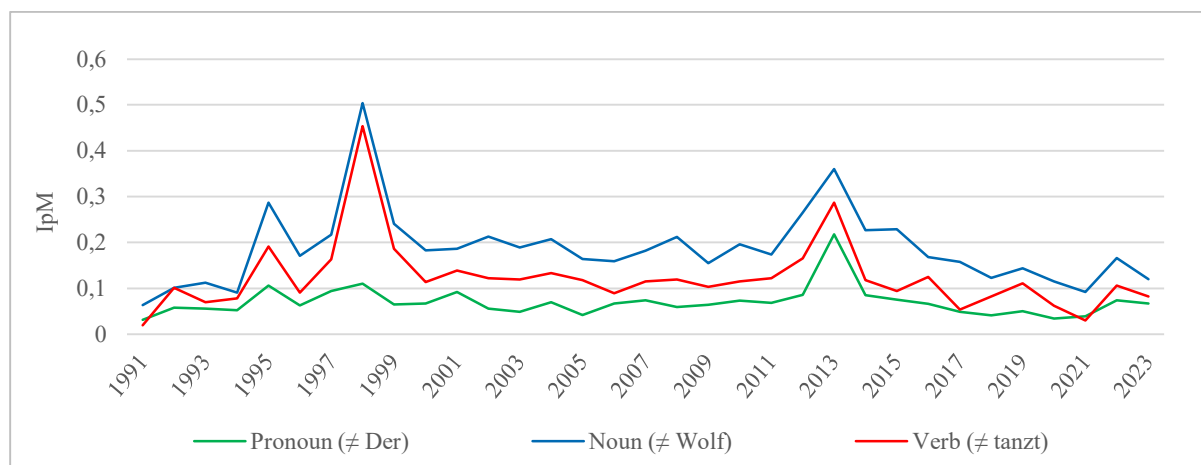


Figure 5: Timeline graph: annual trend of pronoun, noun, and verb modifications (period: 1991–2023, IpM)

a) Pronoun position

Starting with the pronoun position, a closer examination of the modified instances (i.e., attestations other than the source expression, $n=2,171$) reveals that, in line with the search parameters²⁰, the pattern instantiates only three different filler items. The most frequent variant is the singular masculine d-pronoun *der* ‘he who’, which accounts for nearly two-thirds (63.75%, $n=1,385$) of all modified attestations (see example 20). This is followed by two formally identical variants of the German d-pronoun *die*: the plural form ‘those who’ with a proportion of 21.79% ($n=473$), and the singular feminine form ‘she who’, found in 14.46% ($n=314$) of the cases (see examples 21 and 22). The restriction to these three pronoun forms is consistent with the haplology approach outlined above (see Section 3.1), as the replacement of the original *der* with *die* (fem. sg./pl.) is only possible because, in German, these demonstrative pronouns are formally identical to the corresponding relative pronouns as well (cf. *Die (die) mit dem Basilikum singen*; *Die (die) mit dem Dinkel zaubert*). By contrast, the neuter pronoun *das* does not occur in the dataset – a gap that points to an animacy restriction of the pattern, whose usage presupposes a human or at least animate referent.

- (20) **Der** mit dem Navi flüstert (SZ, 20 September 2014)
lit. ‘(He who) Whispers with the satnav’
- (21) **Die** mit dem Basilikum singen (NZZ, 15 October 2015)
lit. ‘(Those who) Sing with the basil’
- (22) **Die** mit dem Dinkel zaubert (KLZ, 15 September 1999)
lit. ‘(She who) Does magic with the spelt’

Although the pronoun position does not constitute a productive slot in the strict sense, being limited to grammatical variation rather than open lexical substitution, it nevertheless functions as a systematic adaptation mechanism, allowing for adjustments in gender and number that make the construction significantly more flexible in use. Notably, the fact that speakers exploit this grammatical flexibility in just over a third of all cases demonstrates its functional relevance for adapting the construction to

²⁰ The search query was deliberately restricted to occurrences of ‘Der’ and ‘Die’ in the pronoun position (see also footnote 15). This limitation was necessary for practical data management and was justified by the fact that no other (pronoun) elements would satisfy the haplological constraints required to preserve recognizability of the source expression.

different referential contexts. This is further supported by Figure 6, which illustrates that the distributional differences even decreased in recent years, as indicated by the converging trend lines. So far, the development points to a potential stabilization in the distribution of pronoun variants, warranting continued observation in future research.

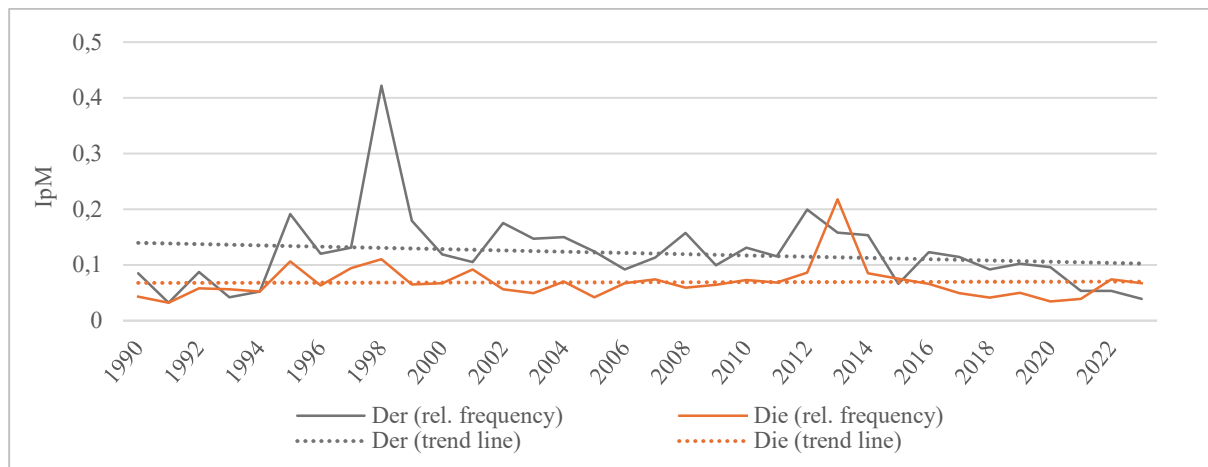


Figure 6: Timeline graph: annual trend of pronoun variation (period: 1991–2023, IpM)

While the pronoun position offers systematic but limited variation, governed by grammatical categories, the actual productivity of the construction arguably resides in its noun and verb positions, albeit to different extents. Both components, subject to lexical rather than grammatical variation, exhibit substantially higher degrees of creative adaptation, pointing to their key function in the film title's transition from a modified to schematic idiom.

b) Noun position

Looking at the noun in more detail, the automatic slot analysis shows that while the source lexeme *Wolf* 'wolf' is still the most frequent noun filler across the entire dataset (39.23%, n=1,332), the majority of instances (60.77%, n=2,063) feature alternative nouns distributed across almost 700 different types. This distribution significantly exceeds the 50% benchmark proposed by Stumpf (2016), providing strong evidence that the noun position is conceptually entrenched as a variable slot which can be instantiated by diverse lexical items. The productivity of this position is further demonstrated by the considerable number of hapaxes – with 462 single-occurrences, hapaxes account for nearly two-thirds (66.19%) of all noun types, including, for instance, *Mammut* ('mammoth'), *Stromschlag* ('electric shock') or *Rollator* ('walker').

As to the semantics of the noun fillers, an in-depth analysis of the modified variants (n=2,171, excluding the source expression) reveals that approximately half of them (46.43%, n=1,008) refer to animate beings, while the other half (53.57%, n=1,163) denote inanimate entities. Within the animate category, animal names dominate, particularly those denoting wild animals (e.g., *Haie* 'sharks', *Löwen* 'lions', *Eisbären* 'polar bears'), semantically close to the title element *Wolf* ('wolf'). Additionally, the animate category includes human referents, which appear either as proper names (e.g., *Putin*, *Trump*, *Scholz*) or as common nouns referring to individuals or groups (e.g., *Chef* 'boss', *Kanzler* 'chancellor', *Nonnen* 'nuns'). The class of inanimate fillers, in contrast, consists primarily of concrete objects (e.g., *Pinsel* 'brush', *Schwert* 'sword', *Staubsauger* 'vacuum cleaner'), complemented by abstract concepts such as *Liebe* 'love', *Schicksal* 'fate', and *Macht* 'power'. Figure 7 presents this distribution in detail, with percentages calculated within each main category (animate/inanimate).

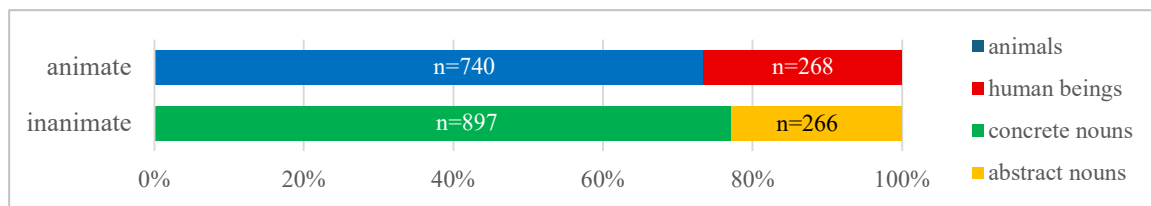


Figure 7: Distribution of noun fillers by semantic category (total: 2,171 tokens)

The semantic categorization of the noun fillers is also interesting from a diachronic point of view, since their progression shows a clear trend reversal over time (Figure 8). While in the first ten years after the film’s release, animate fillers predominated overall, the ratio has been flipped since 2002, with the result that the frequency of inanimate fillers has remained consistently higher now for more than 20 years.

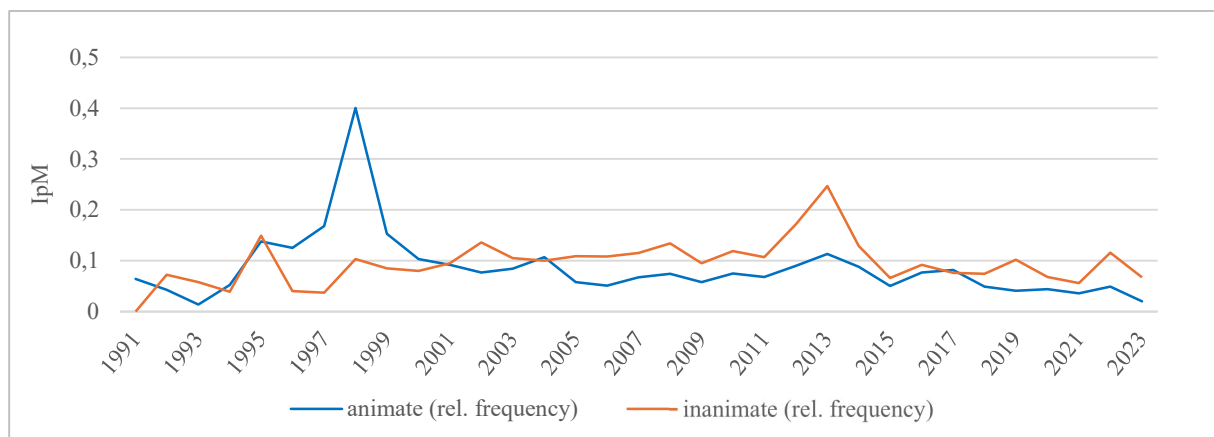


Figure 8: Timeline graph: annual trend of noun fillers by semantic category (animate/inanimate), period: 1991–2023 (IpM)

In conjunction with the timeline data from Figure 4, highlighting the temporal link between the film’s release and the pattern’s growth, the early predominance of animate items documented in Figure 8 provides further evidence that the pattern’s genesis can indeed be traced back to the film title, initially spreading through analogy-based extensions with speakers replacing *Wolf* with semantically related nouns from the same or a similar category. Given this striking semantic relatedness, the early substitutes remained clearly anchored in the source concept, reflecting what Mellado Blanco & Ivorra Ordines (2023: 20) call a “cognitive core”. While analogical formations typically maintain semantic similarities between the source lexeme and its substitutes, the subsequent expansion and eventual dominance of inanimate fillers after 2002 then marks a shift toward an increasingly productive process, as evidenced by the semantic diversification that is generally considered as a key indicator of this transition (see, e.g., Bybee 2010: 57; Schmid 2020: 288). However, it is worth noting that this transition is far from clear-cut, occurring in what Stumpf (2025: 234) aptly describes as “a gray area between creative analogy and productive pattern.”

In terms of the underlying developmental processes, the growing semantic diversity of the noun fillers, which can be seen as an instance of “host-class expansion” in the sense of Himmelfmann (2004), illustrates how speakers first modify fixed phrases using semantically homogeneous elements (animate fillers, first phase) before expanding beyond these prototypes toward broader applications (inanimate fillers, second phase). In this line of reasoning, the observed diachronic shift indicates that the pattern, initially driven by E-creativity through analogical extensions that transcend the conventional usage of a winged word, increasingly displays characteristics of F-creativity, where speakers productively apply an emerging schema with more flexible parameters – suggesting that the more conventionalized a pattern

becomes, the more speakers exploit and expand pattern-based options in order to ensure continued communicative effectiveness (see also Eitelmann & Haumann 2022: 2).

Turning to the morphosyntactic features, the filler items are prototypically heads of definite NPs, mirroring the structure of the source construction. An additional search in *DeReKo*, explicitly targeting realizations without a definite article, yields only 65 tokens, including proper names (example 23), alternative determiners such as possessive pronouns (example 24), attributive extensions (example 25) or complements without article (example 26). The overwhelming predominance of the definite article structure indicates its high entrenchment as a constitutive element of the pattern.

(23) Der mit **Bach** swingte (NUN, 8 March 2019)

lit. ‘(He who) Swung with [Johann Sebastian] Bach’

(24) Der mit **seinen Dämonen** kämpft: Stephen King an seinem Tatwerkzeug, der Schreibmaschine (Spiegel-Online, 31 Oktober 2020)

lit. ‘(He who) Battles with his demons: Stephen King with his instrument of crime, the typewriter’

(25) Die mit **Pekings Pandas** tanzt (TAZ, 20 December 2008)

lit. ‘(She who) Dances with Beijing's pandas’

(26) Der mit **Benzin** löscht (Spiegel, 17 January 1951)

lit. ‘(He who) Extinguishes with petrol’

Further slot analysis reveals that the filler items are predominantly singular nouns (67.39%, n=1,463) and, in terms of gender, most commonly masculine (38.83%, n=808). This preference appears to be structurally motivated, as both the number and gender of the noun directly influence the inflection of the definite article. Indeed, almost half of all modifications occur with the preceding definite article *dem*; remarkably, a substantial share of these cases (22.32%, n=258) involve neuter nouns, whose definite article in German dative case (*dem*) is identical to that of masculine nouns, allowing for substitution without requiring an inflectional adjustment (example 27 and 28). The remaining instances requiring article modification comprise feminine nouns (14.14%, n=307) with *der* (example 29) and, somewhat more frequently, plural nouns (32.61%, n=708) with *den* (example 30).

(27) Der mit **dem** Salto jubelt (NKU, 20 February 2021)

(sg m)

lit. ‘(He who) Cheers with the somersault’

(28) Der mit **dem** Brot badet (Spiegel-Online, 12 February 2011)

(sg n)

lit. ‘(He who) Bathes with the bread’

(29) Der mit **der** Heizung kuschelt (BZT, 6 November 2017)

(sg f)

lit. ‘(He who) Cuddles with the heater’

(30) Die mit **den** Ohren sehen (NKU, 19 January 2002)

(pl)

lit. ‘(Those who) See with the ears’

The associated timeline graph in Figure 9 shows that the quantitative distribution of the three article forms is also reflected in their diachronic development. Except for 1998 – when the publication of Monty Roberts’ biography *Der mit den Pferden spricht* (orig. *The man who listens to horses*) led to a temporary surge in occurrences with *den* –, realizations with the source article *dem* consistently dominate over time. Plural forms (*den*) rank second, while feminine forms (*der*) occur least frequently, a hierarchy that broadly persists throughout the observed period, as evident from the trend lines.

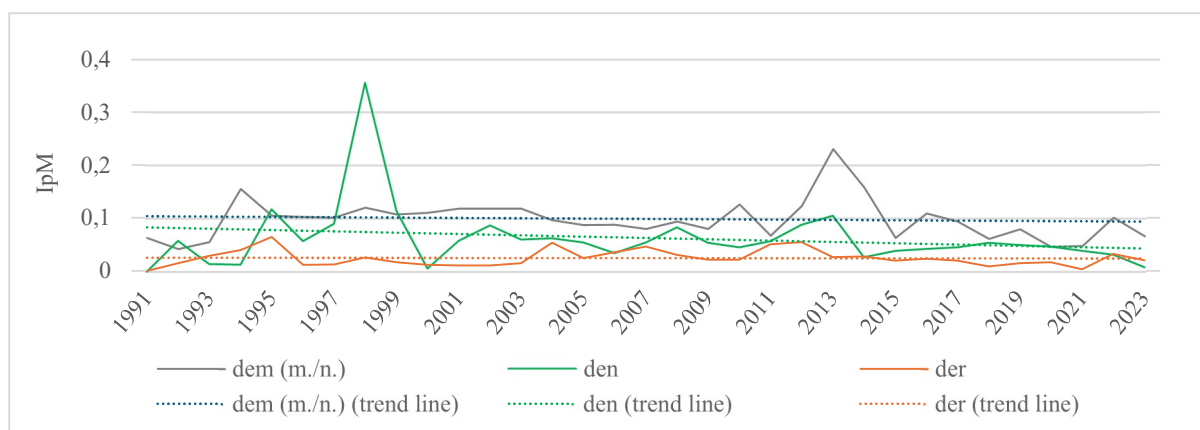


Figure 9: Timeline graph: annual trend of definite article variation (period: 1991–2023, IpM)

In sum, the findings suggest that the morphosyntactic features of the source element *Wolf* serve as a flexible guideline for filling the noun slot. While deviations in number and gender are possible, thereby significantly expanding the construction’s usage range, the diachronic dominance of the masculine singular form persists as a clear marker that it has firmly established itself as the prototypical variant of the construction. This interpretation is further supported by the observed syntactic simplicity of the noun phrases involved. A review of the data reveals that attributive extensions occur in merely 28 cases, primarily as adjectival attributes (examples 31). This limited syntactic complexity further demonstrates how the construction continues to preserve certain structural characteristics of its origin while allowing for controlled morphosyntactic variation.

- (31) a. Der mit dem **rechten Auge** sieht (DPR, 2 October 2022)
lit. ‘(He who) Sees with the right eye’
b. Die mit den **musikalischen Stilen** spielen (RHZ, 24 June 2008)
lit. ‘(Those who) Play with the musical styles’

Taken together, the noun slot shows considerable flexibility, licensing a wide range of fillers that differ both semantically (animate vs. inanimate) and morphosyntactically (variation in number, gender, and article choice), while maintaining a generally simple phrase structure. Having established these characteristics of the noun slot, we now turn to examining the verb position, which represents another crucial element of the construction, albeit one with notably different characteristics.

c) Verb position

The analysis of the verb position reveals a striking contrast with the previously examined noun position. A closer look at the respective filler inventories (see Tables 3 and 4) shows a substantially more limited range of verbal elements: only 177 distinct verbs (types)²¹ were identified, which amounts to merely a quarter of the nominal variety, with nearly 700 types attested. This limited number of distinct verbs also correlates with a significantly higher token frequency of the source lexeme, as occurrences of *tanz* ‘dances’ exceed those of *Wolf* ‘wolf’ by more than a third in percentage terms (approximately 66% vs. 39%).

Filler	Tokens	%
<i>Wolf</i> (‘wolf’)	1,332	39.23
<i>Pferden</i> (‘horses’)	150	4.42

Filler	Tokens	%
<i>tanzen</i> (‘to dance’)	2,229	65.67
<i>sprechen</i> (‘to speak’)	300	8.84

²¹ To focus exclusively on the lexical diversity of the verb slot, verbal fillers were lemmatized to their base forms, disregarding inflectional variations resulting from the choice of the initial d-pronoun (e.g., *tanzte/tanzten* → *tanzen*).

<i>Ball</i> ('ball')	88	2.59
<i>Liebe</i> ('love')	86	5.53
<i>Wölfen</i> ('wolves')	73	2.15
<i>Bauch</i> ('belly')	51	1.50
<i>Stimme</i> ('voice')	37	1.09
<i>Wind</i> ('wind')	35	1.03
<i>Hund</i> ('dog')	32	0.94
<i>Wort</i> ('word')	28	0.82
<i>Golf</i> ('golf')	27	0.80
<i>Blut</i> ('blood')	26	0.77
<i>Teufel</i> ('devil')	26	0.77
<i>Bären</i> ('bears')	24	0.71
<i>Raben</i> ('raven')	21	0.62
...	...	...

Table 3: First 15 of 698 different noun fillers (total number of hits: 3,395)

<i>spielen</i> ('to play')	191	5.63
<i>heulen</i> ('to cry')	61	1.80
<i>kämpfen</i> ('to fight')	40	1.18
<i>flüstern</i> ('to whisper')	33	0.97
<i>sehen</i> ('to see')	31	0.91
<i>leben</i> ('to live')	26	0.77
<i>malen</i> ('to paint')	24	0.71
<i>schwimmen</i> ('to swim')	23	0.68
<i>fliegen</i> ('to fly')	21	0.62
<i>unterschreiben</i> ('to sign')	21	0.62
<i>singen</i> ('to sing')	19	0.56
<i>reden</i> ('to talk')	13	0.38
<i>fahren</i> ('to drive')	12	0.35
...	...	...

Table 4: First 15 of 177 different verb fillers (total number of hits: 3,395)

The remarkably high frequency of *tanz* 'dances' relative to other verb fillers indicates the emergence of a distinct subschema of the form [DER *mit* NP_{dat} *tanz*] 'The one who) Dances with NP_{dat}', characterized by greater lexical fixedness than its less specified counterpart [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}]. Given that schematization requires variability rates above 50% (cf. Stumpf 2016), the clear dominance of *tanz* – accounting for as much as 60% of verb occurrences – indicates that speakers perceive this structure as a relatively stable unit with a fixed verb component. Consequently, the subschema [DER *mit* NP_{dat} *tanz*] qualifies as a construction in its own right – a meso-construction in the sense of Traugott (2008: 236) –, located nearer to the lexical pole on the syntax-lexicon continuum and thus reflecting an intermediate level of divergence from the source phraseme along the derivational trajectory of snowcloning.

At the same time, the dominance of *tanz* raises theoretical questions about the precise status of the more general schema [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}]. Strictly following Stumpf's criteria, the verb position does not fully meet the requirements for schematicity, since its variability remains too limited to exhibit the openness typically associated with schematic elements. However, this dominance does not equate to full lexicalization, as numerous alternative verb fillers remain attested.

Interestingly, a diachronic analysis of the two patterns – counted separately, with instances of *tanz* assigned exclusively to the specific subschema [DER *mit* NP_{dat} *tanz*] and excluded from the more general schema – offers a complementary perspective: when comparing their frequency trajectories over time (see Figure 10), we find that, despite annual fluctuations, their median values are nearly identical, indicating that language users employed both schemas more or less equally over time. This balanced distribution suggests that both constructions occupy stable positions in the constructional network, occupying distinct yet complementary functional niches. Rather than one pattern displacing the other, we observe what Ziem (2022) describes as 'constructional division of labor' with each pattern covering its own semantic-pragmatic territory for related but distinctive communicative purposes.

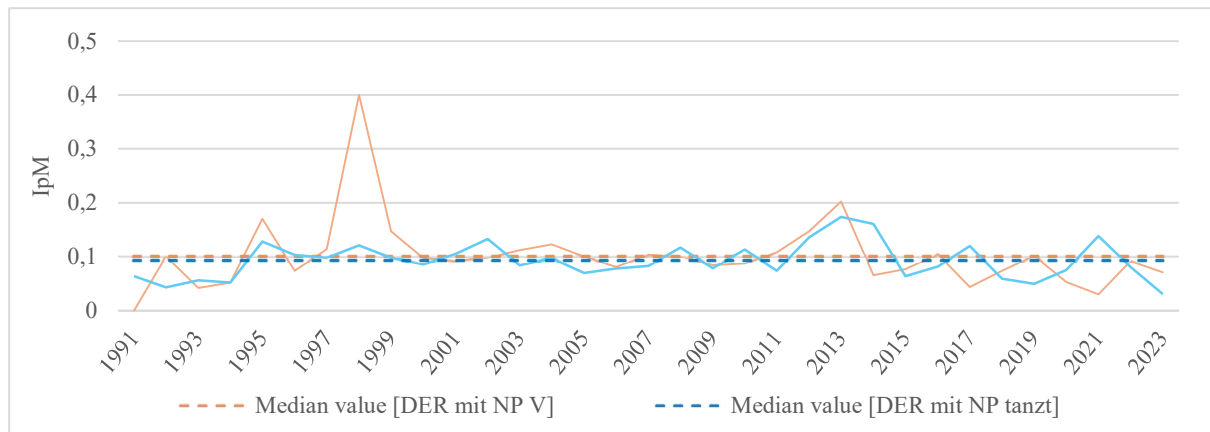


Figure 10: Timeline graph: annual trend of pattern variants [DER mit NP_{dat} V_{fin}] vs. [DER mit NP_{dat} tanzt] (period: 1991–2023, IpM)

To examine this functional differentiation more closely, we now turn to the semantic and pragmatic characteristics of each construction variant in detail. Firstly, the pattern with *tanzt* ‘dances’ reveals two complementary yet distinct modes of use: a more literal interpretation linked to physical movement and a more abstract one emphasizing virtuosity. In literal cases, we encounter examples such as that of Martin Schäfer (example 32), a sculptor who ‘dances’ with a chainsaw while creating art. As the source text vividly describes, Schäfer brought so much momentum to the work with his chainsaw that the entire process evoked the impression of a dance.

- (32) Mit einer Kettensäge zu tanzen, das mag für viele vorsichtige Kunst-Freunde keine so prickelnde Vorstellung sein. Der Wormser Skulpturen-Künstler Martin Schäfer hatte davor jedoch keine Angst und machte sich an einem Pappel-Baumstamm mit der Kettensäge zu schaffen. Viel Schwung brachte er hinein in den hölzernen Klotz, sodass ihn sein gesagtes Endergebnis an einen Tanz erinnerte. [...] Martin Schäfer – oder auch „**Der mit der Kettensäge tanzt**“ – erhielt von der Jury den ersten Preis [...]. (MM, 10 October 2006)

‘Dancing with a chainsaw may not be such a thrilling prospect for many cautious art lovers. However, the Worms-based sculptor Martin Schäfer was not afraid of this and set to work on a poplar tree trunk with a chainsaw. He brought a lot of momentum into the wooden block, so that the final result reminded him of a dance. [...] Martin Schäfer – or “**the one who dances with the chainsaw**” – received the first prize from the jury [...].’

In its abstract usage, however, the movement aspect of dancing gradually fades, giving way to a more figurative interpretation. As examples (33) and (34) demonstrate, *tanzt* is used metaphorically to convey that the person referred to possesses exceptional skill in controlling the referent designated by the noun (e.g., *wave*, *helicopter*, *letters*, *crisis*), implying a level of virtuosity that sets this person apart from others in the respective domain. The meaning of *tanzen* ‘dance’ thus undergoes significant abstraction: from its literal sense of ‘rhythmic, rule-based movement to music’ to a metaphorical reading where dancing as ‘exceptionally skilled movement’ is reframed as ‘exceptionally skilled handling of N’.

- (33) a. Der mit den Wellen tanzt (HMP, 19 September 2005)
lit. ‘(He who) Dances with the waves’
b. Der mit dem Hubschrauber tanzt (NUN, 12 October 2011)
lit. ‘(He who) Dances with the helicopter’
- (34) a. Der mit den Buchstaben tanzt (NON, 12 March 2008)
lit. ‘(He who) Dances with the letters’
b. Der mit der Krise tanzt (Spiegel-Online, 2 September 2020)
lit. ‘(He who) Dances with the crisis’

In these examples, we can clearly observe the gradual shift from a literal to a more abstract use of the verb: In the first two cases (33), *tanzt* retains a stronger link to physical movement, relating to the skillful navigation of concrete, physically grounded elements (e.g., surfing waves, maneuvering a helicopter). Here, the figurative meaning of virtuosity is built upon the original sense of the verb, largely preserving the notion of coordinated movement. The latter two examples (34), by contrast, exhibit a markedly weaker connection to physicality, with *tanzt* becoming fully metaphorical and signifying the creative mastery of more abstract issues (e.g., handling language or managing crises).

This metaphorical flexibility of *tanzen* may partially account for its relative stability in the construction and the markedly asymmetric modification rates between the noun (60%) and verb (35%) positions. While *tanzen* exhibits high metaphorical adaptability, extending from physical movement to abstract virtuosity and thus applying across diverse conceptual domains, *Wolf*, by contrast, shows far more limited activation potential, reflecting its lower communicative salience: speakers frequently encounter situations calling for the conceptualization of ‘dancing’ – whether literal or extended – yet relatively few everyday scenarios that would prompt them to invoke the concept of ‘wolf’. The result is a functional asymmetry whereby the verb position, anchored by a lexeme with broad applicability, remains more stable, while the noun position, lacking comparable communicative scope, proves far more susceptible to creative variation.

Having explored the semantic nuances offered by the pattern with *tanzt*, we now turn to a broader analysis of the pattern variant with an open verb slot, which presents a more complex picture as the 177 distinct verb fillers form a highly heterogeneous group (see Table 5 for a representative selection). As for the semantic verb classes, we find a predominance of action verbs directed toward specific results (e.g., *bauen* ‘build’, *bügeln* ‘iron’, *kochen* ‘cook’), with a noticeable prevalence of verbs related to creative activities (e.g., *malen* ‘paint’, *dichten* ‘write poetry’, *musizieren* ‘make music’). In addition, several other semantic sets are attested, including motion verbs that conceptualize physical movement or position change, especially in sports contexts (e.g., *schwimmen* ‘swim’, *radeln* ‘cycle’, *kicken* ‘kick’), verbs denoting social interaction or communication (e.g., *flirten* ‘flirt’, *knutschen* ‘kiss’, *diskutieren* ‘discuss’), and verbs referring to mental processes that conceptualize thoughts, feelings, or perceptions (e.g., *denken* ‘think’, *träumen* ‘dream’, *philosophieren* ‘philosophize’). Overall, the high proportion of verbs denoting externally perceptible actions reinforces the designative function of the pattern, a point I will elaborate on further below.

<i>arbeiten</i> (‘work’), <i>aufwachen</i> (‘wake up’), <i>baden</i> (‘bathe’), <i>bauen</i> (‘build’), <i>bezahlen</i> (‘pay’), <i>bügeln</i> (‘iron’), <i>crashen</i> (‘crash’), <i>dealen</i> (‘deal’), <i>denken</i> (‘think’), <i>dichten</i> (‘write poetry’), <i>dirigieren</i> (‘conduct’), <i>diskutieren</i> (‘discuss’), <i>dolmetschen</i> (‘interpret’), <i>erzählen</i> (‘tell’), <i>essen</i> (‘eat’), <i>fühlen</i> (‘feel’), <i>feiern</i> (‘celebrate’), <i>fischen</i> (‘fishing’), <i>fotografieren</i> (‘take photos’), <i>geben</i> (‘give’), <i>geizen</i> (‘be stingy’), <i>handeln</i> (‘trade’), <i>hausen</i> (‘live’), <i>hexen</i> (‘do magic’), <i>jagen</i> (‘hunt’), <i>jazzen</i> (‘jazz’), <i>kicken</i> (‘kick’), <i>klettern</i> (‘climb’), <i>knuddeln</i> (‘cuddle’), <i>komponieren</i> (‘compose’), <i>kungeln</i> (‘collude’), <i>laufen</i> (‘run’), <i>lenken</i> (‘steer’), <i>lernen</i> (‘learn’), <i>musizieren</i> (‘make music’), <i>paddeln</i> (‘paddle’), <i>paktieren</i> (‘pact’), <i>philosophieren</i> (‘philosophize’), <i>planschen</i> (‘splash’), <i>plaudern</i> (‘chat’), <i>radeln</i> (‘cycle’), <i>rappen</i> (‘rap’), <i>reisen</i> (‘travel’), <i>rodeln</i> (‘toboggan’), <i>rudern</i> (‘row’), <i>rutschen</i> (‘slide’), <i>scherzen</i> (‘joke’), <i>schießen</i> (‘shoot’), <i>schimpfen</i> (‘scold’), <i>schlafen</i> (‘sleep’), <i>schmusen</i> (‘cuddle’), <i>schunkeln</i> (‘sway’), <i>schweigen</i> (‘remain silent’), <i>simsen</i> (‘text’), <i>Skilaufen</i> (‘go skiing’), <i>springen</i> (‘jump’), <i>sprinten</i> (‘sprint’), <i>streiten</i> (‘argue’), <i>surfen</i> (‘surf’), <i>swingen</i> (‘swing’), <i>trinken</i> (‘drink’), <i>überleben</i> (‘survive’), <i>unterzeichnen</i> (‘sign’), <i>winken</i> (‘wave’), <i>wohnen</i> (‘live’), <i>zaubern</i> (‘do magic’), <i>zeichnen</i> (‘draw’)

Table 5: Excerpt of the 177 attested filler verbs (selection of low-frequency types with fewer than five occurrences)

Turning to morphosyntax, the verb fillers show a strong tendency towards simple verb stems (e.g., *sprechen* ‘speak’, *spielen* ‘play’, *kämpfen* ‘fight’), leading to a higher occurrence of monosyllabic forms (e.g., *spricht* ‘speaks’, *spielt* ‘plays’, *kämpft* ‘fights’). This preference aligns with the source lexeme of the film title, which likewise features a simple verb in monosyllabic form (*tanzt* ‘dances’). In contrast, complex verbs are comparatively rare, consisting mostly of derivatives (e.g., *bezahlen* ‘pay’, *gewinnen* ‘win’, *erringen* ‘gain’), particle verbs (e.g., *aufwachen* ‘wake up’, *mitziehen* ‘pull along’, *einschweben* ‘float in’), or verbal multi-word expressions (e.g., *aus der Reihe tanzen* ‘step out of line’, *Schritt halten* ‘keep pace’). This distribution is even more striking at the token level, where simple verbs account for

3,944 out of 3,995 instances (98.72%), with only one complex verb (*unterschreiben* ‘sign’, n=21) among the twenty most frequent fillers.

Beyond that, the verb types differ in various syntactic features, e.g. in terms of transitivity, further contributing to their heterogeneity. The only consistent syntactic constraint on verb selection appears to be compatibility with a prepositional phrase introduced by *mit* (‘with’). This applies regardless of whether these function as valency-bound prepositional objects (e.g., *streiten* ‘argue’, *dealen* ‘deal’, *telefonieren* ‘make a phone call’), as typical but optional complements (e.g., *spielen* ‘play’, *kämpfen* ‘fight’, *knutschen* ‘smooch’), or as adverbial supplements expressing a comitative or instrumental meaning (e.g., *reisen* ‘travel’, *kochen* ‘cook’, *schreiben* ‘write’). This explains why verbs that frequently co-occur with *mit*-phrases are particularly well suited as potential verb fillers.

Apart from this *mit*-compatibility, it becomes evident that verb selection is otherwise influenced more by pragmatic than by syntactic factors. More specifically, the construction serves to characterize a referent through an action (V) performed on an entity (N), which is perceived as a typifying feature of the referent – whether through physical traits, cultural tastes, or communicative practices – as illustrated by the following examples (35).

- (35) a. Der mit den **Muskeln spielt** (HAZ, 5 January 2021)
lit. ‘(He who) Plays with the muscles’
b. Die mit dem **Blues tanzen** (NKU, 2 November 2001)
lit. ‘(Those who) Dance with the Blues’
c. Die mit den **Händen dolmetscht** (NKU, 5 December 2008)
lit. ‘(She who) Interprets with the hands’

Rather than relying on simple characterization, the pattern’s distinctive referential function typically demands an even higher degree of salience than demonstrated above. This is achieved through semantic incongruity between action V and entity N, leading to pairings of elements that draw cognitive attention precisely because they, “at least theoretically, should not be compatible or combinable” (Bergs 2019: 177). As a result, these incongruous combinations function as distinct identificational markers for the referent by marking it as exceptional and ensuring its immediate recognizability across different contexts. In this sense, the pattern follows an ‘incongruity principle’, which aligns with the notion of extravagance identified by Hartmann & Ungerer (2024: 604) as a key criterion for snowclone status (see Section 2). This principle operates on several levels, manifesting in three distinct types of incongruity:

Type 1: Situational incongruity

- (36) a. Der mit dem **Eisbären plantscht** (NKU, 24 September 2012)
lit. ‘(He who) Splashes with the polar bear’
b. Der mit der **Python surft** (TAZ, 19 September 2023)
lit. ‘(He who) Surfs with the python’
c. Der mit dem **Löwen kuschelt** (SGT, 27 March 2019)
lit. ‘(He who) Cuddles with the lion’

This type encompasses activities with entities that would not normally occur in reality. Just as *dancing with a wolf* represents an unlikely scenario due to the animal’s wild nature, *splashing around with a polar bear* or *surfing with a python* also challenge expectations of human-animal interactions. Here, the incongruity arises from the fact that the situations described contradict real-world plausibility.

Type 2: Functional incongruity

- (37) a. Der mit dem **Wok rodelt** (BMP, 7 November 2003)
lit. ‘(He who) Toboggans with the wok’
b. Die mit der **Schere zeichnet** (SZ, 10 June 2016)

- lit. ‘(She who) Draws with scissors’
- c. Der mit dem **Stift denkt** (SGT, 26 January 2021)
lit. ‘(He who) Thinks with a pen’

This subtype of situational incongruity involves entities being used contrary to their conventional functions or purposes. This occurs, for example, when a *wok* is used for *tobogganing* rather than cooking, *scissors* serve for *drawing* instead of for cutting, or when a *pen* is metaphorically linked to *thinking* rather than writing. Such functional subversions disrupt conventional object-use patterns, creating an incongruity that challenges familiar associations and prompts reinterpretation.

Type 3: Categorical incongruity

- (38) a. Der mit der **Luft schimpft** (Jens Rachut, 2020)
lit. ‘(He who) Discusses with the hairdryer’
- b. Die mit dem **Pfeffer flirtet** (LTB, 6 August 2019)
lit. ‘(She who) Flirts with the pepper’
- c. Der mit den **Promis jongliert** (TTZ, 23 January 1998)
lit. ‘(He who) Juggles celebrities’

This type represents the most extreme form of incongruity, involving verb-noun combinations deemed impossible due to fundamental categorical mismatches – such as applying typically human activities (*arguing*, *flirting*) to inanimate objects (*air*, *pepper*), or vice versa extending object-related verbs (*juggling*) metaphorically to people (*celebrities*).

The high frequency of incongruent filler combinations reveals semantic incongruity as a key characteristic of the pattern, amplifying its core function of designating ‘a person who, in contrast to others, is characterized by action V on entity N’ (cf. Garski 2008: 111). Before contextualizing this characteristic within the pattern’s primary discourse functions, the following section briefly summarizes the main findings of the case study concerning the construction’s productivity and snowclone status.

3.3 Interim conclusion: empirical findings and theoretical implications

The corpus analysis yields three key observations supporting the emergence of a constructional idiom that, in addition, qualifies as a snowclone. First, based on the entire dataset of 3,395 occurrences from the *DeReKo*, speakers strongly favor creative adaptations of the film title (63.95%) over its canonical form (36.05%), with the modification rate clearly exceeding the 50% benchmark proposed by Stumpf (2016) for distinguishing semi-schematic idioms from mere occasional idiom modifications. With over 1,100 distinct types and numerous hapaxes overall, the pattern exhibits systematic variation across three structural positions: the pronoun (limited to three options), the noun (highly diverse with over 698 types), and the verb (dominated by *tanz* yet accommodating 177 different filler types). These findings demonstrate that we are dealing here with structurally inherent slots rather than modified phraseological constituents, indicating a productive semi-schematic construction of the form of [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}], alongside the consolidation of a distinct subschema [DER *mit* NP_{dat} *tanz*] that operates in parallel.

Second, the diachronic timeline analysis provides clear empirical support for the snowclone status of this pattern, demonstrating a clear etymological link to a fixed and culturally salient source expression, which manifests in the temporal coincidence between the film’s release and the rapid growth of analogous realizations. This is evidenced by a sharp rise in occurrences of this distinct type of haplogological relative structure from 1991 onwards, with modified forms surpassing the title expression in frequency as early as 1995. While structurally similar forms existed prior to 1991, their occurrence remained marginal (low double digits), clearly indicating that the film served as the catalyst for popularizing and spreading a previously non-productive template, which is fully in line with Hartmann

& Ungerer's (2024: 603) remark that the source construction of a snowclone need not necessarily coincide with the earliest attestation of the pattern.

Third, building on this diachronic evidence, the analysis reveals a clear shift in the underlying creative processes. In its early phase, the development qualifies as E-creative, as the variation of a fixed and widely recognized film title deliberately broke with the expected structure of a familiar winged word. As these norm violations were repeated over time, speakers began to perceive recurring similarities among them – paving the way for generalization. Rather than treating more than 2,000 variations as isolated acts of rule-breaking, it becomes more plausible to assume that a new schema has entrenched by way of previous norm violations becoming paradigmatic (F-creative). Notably, this process of creative expansion unfolds differently across the three slots. The noun position exhibits the most pronounced shift, particularly with regard to semantic dispersion, moving from largely homogeneous fillers in early attestations (animal/animate) to increasingly heterogeneous types (inanimate), reflecting the transition from narrowly defined lexical replacements toward a highly flexible slot. The pronoun position, though structurally limited to three forms, indicates F-creative schema application by extending beyond its original masculine singular base through systematic gender and number variation. Finally, the verb position shows an intensifying tendency toward semantic incongruity, progressing from situational incongruity (as in the original *tanz* 'dances') toward functional (type 2) and categorical incongruities (type 3) which suggests that speakers have learned to exploit incongruity as a conventionalized design feature of the verb slot, systematically creating unexpected verb-noun combinations to enhance referential distinctiveness.

In this sense, the pattern also exhibits extravagant characteristics typical of snowclones, manifesting both on a structural and semantic level: semantically extravagant through its systematic reliance on incongruous slot fillings that combines semantically incompatible or at least not trivially related concepts, and structurally extravagant through syntactic desintegration enabled by its specific haplogically-derived relative structure – both representing striking deviations from linguistic standards and expectations. In this way, the construction exemplifies how snowclones can derive their extravagant effects directly from their source expressions that first popularized these innovative features and thereby acquired their cultural salience as templates for creative adaptation.

Taken together, the results of this corpus-driven diachronic study provide robust evidence for the snowclone status of [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}], illustrating how analogy-driven modification, anchored in memorable lines of culturally significant artifacts like film titles, can give rise to a new partly schematic construction whose 'life cycle', despite its relatively recent origin in the present case, points not to a 'fleeting', merely short-lived phenomenon but to a stable linguistic resource that has already persisted for nearly three decades.

4. Usage characteristics: [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] as a title template

Having established the pattern's productive status and traced its diachronic development, this section examines how the construction functions in discourse, showing that its specialized usage cannot be explained by structural and semantic properties alone. From a pragmatic perspective, acting upon an entity in a manner that defies everyday reality serves a dual purpose: it foregrounds a salient individual trait of the person in question while simultaneously operating as a distinct referential expression allowing for unique identification. This is particularly relevant given that a systematic analysis of corpus data reveals two closely related functional categories of the construction, which are in line with the twofold function of *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt*. Firstly, as illustrated in example (39), the construction serves as a 'naming template' that generates descriptive and expressive nicknames for individuals. Unlike official names, these designations emphasize salient character traits shaped by the underlying incongruous noun-verb pairing:

- (39) Hans Wiedeschitz – „**Der mit dem Mörtel malt**“ – lädt [...] zu seiner ersten Veranstaltung in die Galerie „Kunst am Zug“ ein. Wiedeschitz und andere Künstler präsentieren [...] ihre Werke aus den Bereichen Fotografie und Design, Holzarbeiten, Keramik und Keramikbilder, Mörtelmalerei, Skulpturen, Tiffany und Zinnfiguren. (Zeit Online, 30 May 2001)

‘Hans Wiedeschitz – “**The one who paints with mortar**” – invites you to his first event at the “Kunst am Zug” gallery [...]. Wiedeschitz and other artists will present [...] their works from the fields of photography and design, woodwork, ceramics and ceramic pictures, mortar painting, sculptures, Tiffany and pewter figures.’

What is more, like the source construction, the pattern not only serves as a naming template for people, but very often for entitling the texts²² that center on the persons characterized in this way. Remarkably, this applies to more than 95% of all corpus instances (excluding the source expression), pointing to a distinct usage pattern strongly associated with titling practices. As previously shown in Table 2 (see Section 3.2.2), the most frequent instantiations of the pattern are indeed book and film titles, exemplified by works such as *Der mit den Pferden spricht* (lit. ‘He who talks to horses’) about horse whisperer Monty Roberts (n=130) and *Die mit der Liebe spielen* (lit. ‘Those who play with the love’), an internationally acclaimed Italian film drama (n=86). These media titles typically exhibit high token frequencies due to repeated mentions in book reviews, film critiques, and program listings, but comprise a relatively small number of distinct types.²³ Additional searches on *amazon.de* and in the German *Directory of Available Books* (“Verzeichnis lieferbarer Bücher”), however, revealed over 70 further titles across diverse media formats, suggesting that the pattern’s use as a naming template for artistic products is considerably more extensive than the newspaper-dominated corpus alone suggests. By contrast, within the corpus itself, a substantial portion of the instances appears in headlines of newspaper articles, as illustrated in (40).

- (40) Der mit dem Mörtel malt (BVZ, 7 May 2015)
lit. ‘(He who) Paints with mortar’

Such instances, which occur only rarely or even just once in the corpus, account for the vast majority of filler types and thus contribute significantly to the pattern’s overall productivity. With over 1,318 attestations, journalistic headlines represent by far the most prevalent application context. Given this overwhelming preference for exposed text positions – where, statistically, one would expect fewer occurrences than in running text – the question arises what drives this specialized usage. I argue that two factors are particularly relevant, both linked to its special snowclone genesis.

The first, which is likely applicable to all snowclones, concerns the dynamic interplay between exposed text positions and modification events. This observation aligns with the broader understanding that snowclones, by definition, emerge from modification processes (see Section 2). Due to their specific function of creating reading incentives, newspaper headlines provide fertile ground for linguistic creativity and are even subject to the kind of ‘creative pressure’ that Sakowski (2017: 109) identifies as particularly evident in commercially driven texts requiring innovative language use. Modified phrasemes respond well to this pressure: by breaking with familiar structures, they attract attention and challenge reader expectations, thereby creating cognitive stimuli that foster cognitive engagement (see also Jaki 2014: 39–41; Sabban 2007: 249). Their hybrid nature – familiar enough to be recognizable yet novel to be striking – creates an interpretive puzzle that offer the intellectual pleasure of decoding (cf. Sabban 2007: 245; Ifantidou 2009: 713). This connection is also empirically supported as quantitative

²² Following Adamzik (2016), the term ‘text’ is used here in a broad sense, including not only written language but also coherent visual or auditory units (e.g., images, soundtracks, video sequences) that serve a recognizable communicative function and exhibit organized structure.

²³ As Stumpf (2025: 217) emphasizes in this context, such cases do not truly reflect productive slot-filling but the mere repetition of fixed titles – in other words, certain existing instantiations of the construction are repeated rather than instantiating the construction with new lexical material.

studies show that modified phrasemes occur two to three times more frequently in headlines than in less prominent text positions (Sakowski 2017: 110; Garski 2008: 111–112).

From this interplay emerges a feedback loop: headlines strategically employ modifications to attract attention, while these in turn foster the emergence of new partly schematic constructions, which we referred to as snowclones. In addition, the high visibility and regular consumption of headlines ensure repeated exposure of these patterns, prompting their consolidation into productive templates while reinforcing their association with headline contexts. In this way, headings actively contribute to both the creation and consolidation of snowclones, serving as the triggering environments for this special subtype of CIs, which, not coincidentally, first attracted scholarly attention in the journalistic domain (cf. also Hartmann & Ungerer 2024: 629, who propose journalistic texts as the “natural habitat of snowclones”).

However, this modification-based explanation alone does not fully account for the striking concentration of [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] in title and headline contexts. What distinguishes this particular pattern is that its headline function derives inherently from its source expression which operates within the same discursive niche, suggesting that snowclones can evoke the specific contexts to which their pattern bases are tied. As Finkbeiner (2021: 263–269) explains, textual elements usually acquire their headline status through formal *designation* as headlines, including visual markers such as spatial separation (e.g., initial capitalization, line breaks) and typographic distinctions (e.g., font size, weight, or typeface), which signal their headline function before reading (see also Reißig 2015).²⁴ Beyond these conventional markers, the pattern in question incorporates an additional layer of interpretative guidance through its origin as a film title. Unlike other snowclones that may occur in both headline and non-headline contexts (see Stutz 2024), this pattern has inherited not only formal and semantic properties from its lexicalized counterpart (see Section 3.2.2) but also distinct discourse features, establishing a tight functional link to specific contextual settings. As a result of this inheritance, the construction acquires a contextualization potential that directs it toward a specific usage domain, creating strong associations with titling practices.

The key to understanding this phenomenon lies in the concept of “contextual entrenchment” (Schmid 2015: 14), which extends traditional notions of entrenchment (cf. Langacker 1987; Goldberg 2006) by emphasizing the habitual pairing of linguistic forms with specific discourse environments. According to Schmid (2015: 14), frequent exposure to linguistic forms in a particular environment strengthens their pragmatic associations, increasing the likelihood of their activation in similar situations. In essence, through this type of entrenchment, the usage characteristic of the snowclone base becomes cognitively integrated into the snowclone itself, creating strong expectations among both producers and recipients regarding its appropriate usage domain, which over time becomes an integral part of the speakers’ construction knowledge (cf. Schmid 2020: 213; see also Ivorra Ordines & Mellado Blanco 2025: 342–344). The case of [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] illustrates this particularly well as the title origin of the winged word has entrenched the discursive role of the snowclone as a titling device, thus predisposing it for similar usage in related environments (see also Östman 2005 on the notion of “discourse pattern”).

The shift from film title to newspaper headlines in fact reinforces this argument. The pattern successfully transferred from one title domain (film) to another (newspaper headlines) precisely because it carries over a generalized titling function, demonstrating that contextual entrenchment operates not at the level of medium, but of discursive function: the pattern activates expectations of titling regardless of whether it precisely appears in film, book, or newspaper contexts. Consequently, what emerges is a genre-indicating formula – a ‘title template’ – that activates headline expectations through both conventional typographic cues and deeply entrenched pragmatic associations. The special case that exists here, where a ‘title forms further titles’ (cf. Bebermeyer & Bebermeyer 1977: 16) exemplifies Schmid’s (2015) concept of contextual entrenchment in its purest form as the usage environment is no longer merely a pragmatic option or preference but has become an integral part of the construction’s cognitive profile.

²⁴ Note that several headlines also feature distinctive grammatical markers that signal their headline status, such as systematic omission of determiners, auxiliaries, or copula verbs – phenomena captured by terms like ‘headline syntax’ (Sandig 1971) or, in a broader sense, ‘headlinese’ (Mårdh 1980).

Its haplological, syntactically non-integrated structure further reinforces this specialization, making it especially suited for standalone, paratextual positions where sentence integration is neither expected nor required.

Beyond these two diachronic explanations, the pattern's effectiveness as a headline device can be explained in functional terms. What makes this pattern particularly attractive for newspaper headlines is its suitability for creating what Sandig (1971) refers to as 'topic headings' ("Themaüberschriften"). Unlike conventional hard news headlines ("Schlagzeilen" or "Resümeeüberschriften"), which reproduce article content in condensed form, topic headings are non-assertive by nature: they primarily fulfill a metacommunicative function by indicating the subject of the upcoming article, i.e., announcing what follows rather than summarizing it (see also Tschauder 1991). For instance, the headline in (40) – *Der mit dem Mörtel malt* ('He who paints with mortar') – is not interpreted as reporting that a man has painted with mortar, but rather as signaling that the article says something about a person characterized by this unusual and newsworthy painting practice. Topic headings, in this sense, do not make explicit propositions but merely presuppose the existence of their referent (here: someone who paints with mortar), leaving the 'macro-proposition' to be elaborated in the article itself. In other words, such headings create an interpretive gap: their function is not to inform directly, but to frame a topic that is expected to unfold in the subsequent text (cf. Tschauder 1991: 305). This deliberate withholding of actual content is what gives them their 'enigmatic' quality, making them highly effective curiosity triggers that function as a mechanism of reader engagement or, metaphorically speaking, as reading bites.²⁵

The pattern [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] demonstrates this mechanism particularly well by typically featuring incongruous noun-verb pairings that resist immediate interpretation. For instance, returning to our example in (40), a reader would be likely left wondering who exactly this person is, why he uses mortar instead of paint, and how such a practice has come about. Crucially, the interpretive effort demanded by such incongruous pairings is not accidental but constitutive of the construction's functional profile: the more the verb-noun pairing deviates from everyday experience, the more enigmatic the headline becomes, and the stronger the incentive to bridge the gap by consulting the article text. In this way, [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] integrates the general curiosity-triggering potential of topic headings with its own construction-specific reliance on incongruity, thereby sharpening its status as a highly successful resource for headline-making.

In sum, while modification dynamics explain the general tendency of snowclones to appear in exposed text positions, it is the entrenched association with titling rooted in its source construction that sets [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}] apart. Combined with the pattern's functional effectiveness as an enigmatic curiosity trigger, this contextual entrenchment explains its striking concentration in titles and headlines, making it a highly effective genre-indicating formula.

5. Summary and Outlook

This paper has examined the German constructional idiom [DER *mit* NP_{dat} V_{fin}], (e.g., *Der mit dem Fön diskutiert* 'He who discusses with the hairdryer'), which has not yet been investigated in depth from a linguistic perspective to the best of my knowledge. Using a corpus-based, constructionist approach, this study contributes to ongoing research on linguistic creativity in Construction Grammar – specifically, how creative adaptations of phraseological units give rise to new, semi-schematic constructions, so-called 'snowclones'. These in turn serve as key patterns for analyzing how analogy-driven modifications (E-creativity) can, over time, solidify into entrenched schemata that sanction new tokens (F-creativity), ultimately shaping the constructional architecture of language. Against this background, this study pursued a twofold aim: (1) determining whether modifications of the film title occur frequently and systematically enough to justify assuming an independent, productive construction; and (2)

²⁵ For a relevance-theoretic perspective on curiosity-based headline strategies, see Finkbeiner (2020) and Stumpf & Mollica (2024).

demonstrating how the diachronic trajectory of these modifications confirms the pattern's snowclone status by linking it to a fixed source expression.

In response to these questions, the case study yielded the following results: First, modifications of *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* occur both frequently (63.95% of all attestations) and systematically (over 1,100 distinct variants), clearly surpassing the 50% benchmark proposed by Stumpf (2016) for distinguishing modified idioms from schematic phrasemes. Second, the diachronic timeline analysis revealed a marked increase in variants shortly after the film's release in 1991, with variants quickly outnumbering the original within just four years. This remarkably fast development, providing empirical support for Buerki's (2019: 30) assumption that formulaic language "changes at a rapid pace", reflects the gradual shift from E-creative norm violations – where speakers deliberately modified a familiar film title – to F-creative schema application, as systematic variations at the same structural positions (pronoun, noun, and verb) gave rise to a paradigmatic schema that speakers now systematically apply.

Most significantly, the analysis revealed that the etymological link between the pattern and its source construction is also mirrored in its usage profile, as over 95% of all corpus attestations function as either title units or newspaper headlines. This suggests that snowclones can inherit not only formal and semantic features, but also discursive properties from their source expressions – such as a preference for specific genres or text positions. Like the original title expression, which functions both as an anthroponym (naming the film's protagonist) and an ergonym (naming the film itself), the pattern retains this dual referential role by serving as a naming template for characterizing individuals through surprising action-entity pairings, as well as a titling formula for texts about these individuals. The cognitive association of this linguistic form with specific discourse environments thus constitutes a form of 'contextual entrenchment' (Schmid 2015), showing how the original title function has become integrated into the emerging pattern itself.

Taken together, these findings reveal a striking functional loop: originating from a well-known title unit that, due to the commercial success of the film and its linguistically salient structure, was creatively modified by numerous speakers, the expression developed into a productive pattern, whose realizations almost exclusively function as titles themselves. The development thus follows a circular trajectory leading from a title (stage 1) to a pattern (stage 2) and back to titles again (stage 3) – with pattern abstraction and title production closely linked rather than separate – underscoring that understanding snowclones also entails understanding the sources from which such patterns derive their distinctive usage features.

For Construction Grammar, these results have several theoretical implications, particularly in modeling the interplay of creativity, conventionalization, and discourse. First, they underscore the need to systematically integrate discourse-specific parameters into constructional descriptions by illustrating how contextual entrenchment can impose usage constraints just as strong as formal or semantic restrictions. Second, this study also highlights the value of diachronic approaches in snowclone research for two key purposes: on the one hand, to provide empirical evidence that snowclones indeed originate from specific source expressions – a diagnostic feature that has been largely assumed rather than systematically demonstrated in previous research – and, on the other hand, to gain a better understanding of the factors that shape the life course of snowclones, contributing to their emergence, spreading and eventual decline. Such evidence lends empirical support to usage-based models of linguistic change, while demonstrating the potential of 'timeline graphs' as an appropriate means of visualizing and exploring micro-diachronies in snowcloning (and constructionalization in general) in a more fine-grained, process-oriented manner.

Looking ahead, this case study raises intriguing questions for future research. Firstly, concerning the relationship between snowclones and their lexical bases, it would be worth examining whether similar processes of contextual entrenchment can be observed in other title-based snowclones, suggesting that these form a distinct subtype with shared structural and functional characteristics. Comparative analyses across snowclones derived from different types of source expressions – such as proverbs, quotes, and

titles – might shed light on how the nature of the source shapes the trajectory and discourse role of the resulting pattern. Secondly, given that especially titles are frequently translated rather than adopted directly – and, not least, often deliberately deviate from literal target-language equivalents (cf. Nord 1993) – contrastive research could explore the notion of ‘constructional borrowing’ (Coleman 2016) in this context, more specifically, how translation practices may foster language-specific adaptations and cross-linguistic differences in snowclone formation. Thirdly, returning to the present pattern, it seems worthwhile to investigate whether more recent haplological relative structures additionally varying in the prepositional element (e.g., *Der aus dem Dschungel kam* ‘Hew who came out of the jungle’ or *Die im Salat stochert* ‘She who pokes in the salad’) might represent a new wave of E-creativity. These could point to a scenario where the pattern’s distinctive haplological structure begins to serve as an analogical template for further innovation – suggesting that snowclones are dynamic formations in ongoing interaction with creative language use. In this light, the story of *Der mit dem Wolf tanzt* continues to unfold – still finding its rhythm in the language.

6. References

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